



AMY HORIKAMI

THE
RED WOLF
OF
TALLOUR

ONCE UPON A TIME

Red wolf of Tallour

By Amy Horikami

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Dedication

To my sister, Sarah. Who is not only the best older sister but a healer to my heart and everyone around her. You have a light that shines. Thanks for everything, buddy.

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Chapter 1

Kneeling in front of the small herb garden I grew outside our large cottage gave me peace as my hands dug into the dirt. Weeding my little patch of herbs gave me a sense of purpose in this large city of Gale that was mostly filled with wealthy men, one of those being my father. He was the owner of the largest fish mercantile on this side of the Kingdom; Bedford Fisherman Inc. He was currently sick and has been bedridden for about two weeks now, which was why I was out here gathering some herbs for a tea to help soothe his ailments. Johnny, his second-in-command, and captain of one of his vessels, was running the business while Father rested. He came by often to give Father the reports he required; even though he could barely lift his head off the pillow, he still wanted to run his business no matter how much my mother objected.

“It’s the dead that don’t bring in money, and I’m well enough to look over some reports.” He would tell my mother every time she complained that he should be resting and not working.

It’s probably why he was sick in the first place. He never took a day off and was as dedicated to his company as I was to my garden patch.

Remembering my purpose, I turned to gather the necessary herbs to make a tea that would soothe his cough and placed them in the basket I had to the side. I got distracted when I noticed some new weeds popping up around my patch, and the need to pluck them before they overtook the small area I worked so hard to grow, sidetracked me from my original purpose of coming out here in the first place. I’ve always been fascinated with plants and growing this garden gave me a sense of satisfaction that I needed. This small plot of dirt started to thrive after I volunteered at the local apothecary, which was over a year ago. I’ve learned so much from Healer Benton, who owned the most renowned apothecary in Gale.

Standing up to head back through the kitchen door, I heard a commotion coming from just inside the door.

“Mother, I can’t possibly leave!”

“It will be just for a little while. You’ll be back here in no time at all.” Mother replied, trying to calm my older sister from whatever news she

just received.

Why was she leaving? We didn't have any family that we kept in contact with or visited. Father grew up an orphan and made his way all by himself, and Mother was an only child. Making my way towards them to figure out what was wrong and to see if I could help.

"But why me? Can't Emma go? She's better with that kind of thing anyway," she pleaded.

I opened the back door, stepping inside with my basket in hand, to see what my sister was volunteering me for. They both turned to me, and Beth came rushing forward with her hands reaching towards me. I quickly put the basket down on the counter before she could knock it over and the freshly picked herbs tossed everywhere.

Grabbing her hands, I looked into her deep blue eyes, the opposite of my muddy brown. We were opposites in every way. She was the beauty of the family with her straight blond hair, fair skin, dainty features, and figure. She had many suitors over the years, but she rejected each and every one of them. I had my suspicions it was because of the tall captain in my father's business that kept her from accepting the offers, since every time he came over to give my father his reports, she would blush a deep crimson and her smile was all the more charming towards him than the other men who called.

I took after my mother, who had dark auburn hair. Instead of her curls, I had soft waves that flowed down my back, which I often braided and wrapped around the crown of my head so it wouldn't get dirty from working in the garden. I also inherited her eyes and a few freckles that were only enhanced by my long days in the sun. I can't count how many times my mother scolded me for not wearing a hat to save my complexion, but the sun in my face felt so heavenly since we only had a few months of warmth in our frozen city. While it was wealthy with ore and other precious metals in its mountains, along with plenty of fish in the sea, its weather was anything but agreeable. Winters were frigid, so any amount of sun made it hard for me to care about my complexion.

"Emma, you must help me. I can't possibly leave." Tears were forming in my older sister's eyes and about to spill over onto her cheeks. She was only a year and a half older than my seventeen years. I would be eighteen in a month, though, and finally be of an age to pursue the occupation of my dreams.

“Leaving where?” I asked curiously. My sister was always dramatic, so it couldn’t be as bad as she was making it out to be. I’ve heard them mention the Ladies Academy in the next Kingdom over, but Mother wouldn’t force her to go if she didn’t want to, would she? I, personally, would hate to be in court, talking about fashion, when I could be outside with my hands in the dirt.

“To grandmothers!”

I turned to my mother with wide eyes, not expecting that answer and wondering if she was serious.

“Grandmothers?”

Why was she wanting to send Beth there, and what was I so much better skilled at to have my sister offer me to go in her place? We have only heard stories of my mother’s mother and never have actually met her. She didn’t like to speak of her childhood. She grew up in the town of Tallour, which was a small, secluded, and mysterious town. Some say it was even cursed. Mother escaped when she was young and made her way to Gale, where she met my father.

“There must be some mistake. Why would Mother want you to go there?”

I especially didn’t want to go there!

Mother took a folded letter out of her apron and handed it to me. I glanced over its contents before I read it out loud.

My dearest daughter Sharon,

Oh, how I have missed you and how the years have passed since I have heard from you. I write to you because my health is failing fast, and I was hoping you would be able to send one of your daughters to help me and be a companion to me for a time until I can find a more permanent solution. She would be well taken care of, and it would only be for a month or two. While I know I write to you out of desperation and have no right to ask such a thing since I have neglected you over the years, know I have always loved you.

Love,

Your mother

P.S. I will send a coach to pick up your daughter in a week’s time once I receive your answer.

“She is sick and needs someone to take care of her?” I looked to my mother to confirm my question.

“Yes. While I know I have never spoken of my upbringing, I feel as if I owe her this small favor. I didn’t leave because of her, but she didn’t necessarily make it easy for me to stay.” She paused and sighed, “I would go myself, even though she has asked me to send Beth, but with your father’s health, I cannot leave his side for very long.”

I looked at Beth, whose tears were now streaming down her face at the inevitable situation mother seemed set on. She was right in one thing, though, I was better suited to take care of those who were sick. It is what I did at least three times a week when I volunteered at the local apothecary with Healer Benton. He often let me tag along when he had a house call, so I could learn more of his trade. He said that if I kept it up and learned all that he knew, he would hire me as an assistant when I became of age. My dream to work at the apothecary would come true and maybe, one day, I could open my own medical ward. Maybe, using the skills I have already acquired and putting them into practice continuously for a few months would make me more than qualified.

“I’ll do it. I’ll go instead of Beth.”

“Oh, you would!” My sister pulled me into a tight embrace, and the air left my lungs from her overwhelming gratitude. “Bless you, Emma!”

“No. I need her here to help me with your father. Plus, she has never traveled alone, while you have.”

She was right about Father, but I was more than capable of traveling by myself. Beth just had more experience because she had many friends in Gale who invited her on trips to attend festivals in other kingdoms. She also had more prospects than I did. None of these wealthy men wanted a girl who cared more about her garden and helping others than taking orders and being a quiet and submissive wife.

Which is exactly what I was.

If my hands weren’t in the dirt attending to my herbs, my nose was in a book learning about how I could use the herbs to heal certain ailments. Which is why I attended to my father while Healer Benton was occupied with other patients.

“It will be alright, Mother. I can do it. I’ll leave you notes on what herbal teas will help father when his cough becomes overwhelming.” She looked at me with sad eyes and put a hand on my arm.

“It’s not that I don’t think you’re capable, I just...the town is not what you think it is, and your grandmother...”

“Surely you don’t believe the tales of it being cursed. Why send Beth, then, if you are so worried?”

She didn’t say anything and we both waited, anticipating her answer since she never spoke of her childhood.

“Please, Mother, you know I am more than capable.”

She turned to me and gently grabbed my shoulders with a small smile.

“I know. That is what I am worried about. You are different Emma, in more ways than you know.” She inhaled deeply then closed her eyes. “Fine. I will write my mother back and tell her Emma will be going instead.”

“Oh, thank you, thank you, mother!” Beth squealed with relief, but I was excited to get away from this city and use my knowledge and skills that I have worked so hard to attain.

Chapter 2

After they left me alone in the kitchen, I turned to my basket and grabbed the herbs out to pluck the leaves off the stem and sort them into their individual jars. I also grabbed some lavender to put in a jar next to my father's bed to help him sleep.

Breathing in the soothing aroma made my fingers tingle. I looked down at them, moving my fingers, wondering if I was sensitive to one of the herbs, but that couldn't be the case because I've never had a problem before.

I turned my hands back and forth, the tingling sensation growing stronger. It didn't hurt, but I could definitely feel a warm charge pulsing at each fingertip. I closed my hands one more time, and immediately, the sensation vanished.

Odd.

I brushed it off as being in the dirt and sun too long, so I went to the sink and pumped me a glass of water and drank deeply.

"That's better," I sighed, putting the cup down and grabbing an empty vase to put the lavender in.

I made a mental note to wear my sun hat for shade next time, so I didn't overwork myself.

Walking over to the wooden stove. I picked the empty kettle off the top and took off the lid, placing it under the pump to fill it with water to make my father's tea. After adding wood to the compartment under the stove and lighting it with a match, I made my way to the shelf on the other side of the kitchen that held my books the healer lent me to read the herbs healing properties while the water boiled.

I flipped through its pages that held a bounty of knowledge that I not only loved, but craved. Each herb had a label, a picture, and uses for cooking and healing.

I was so lost in memorizing the knowledge placed before me that I didn't hear the kettle whistle until our cook came in with a basket full of eggs, bread, and supplies she needed for making meals.

"Distracted again, deary." Mrs. Chaff's heavy accent filled the kitchen as she smiled at me. I looked up from my book and found her

already taking the kettle off the stove.

She was a plump woman with brown hair that was tucked under a white cap. She wore spectacles at the edge of her nose with her signature white apron around her waist that always stayed clean somehow.

“Yes, it’s just so fascinating that I can’t seem to get enough of it.”

“You’ll be a great healer one day, deary. I know you will.”

“Thanks, Mrs. Chaff.” I closed the book and headed towards the shelf that I personally had made to hold the jars of herbs I grew and used. Scanning the jars and their labels, I plucked a few from their place that I would use to help soothe my father’s cough and congested chest, along with a small linen bag. Opening the strings, I placed a few of the herbs into the little pouch and tied it off so the herbs wouldn’t spill. Taking a cup from off the high shelf I placed the bag in with the strings going over the edge and poured the hot water in. I’d let it steep for about ten minutes until I brought it up to my father. It was longer than normal, but I wanted all the benefits of the herbs to be strong in his tea.

Mrs. Chaff chatted about going to town and the hustle and bustle it always was.

“Good thing I went early. Mrs. Strenley was coming up the way, and with all those mouths to feed, I knew if I waited one more second, I would not have these here cakes for tonight, I tell you.”

I knew Mrs. Strenley well. She had seven children, and they always had some form of ailment running through their home at one point or another. The healer and I often visited to give remedies to help relieve their symptoms. Every time I got the chance, I would bring a basket full of food to help ease the burden of filling so many mouths.

“Cakes?” Realizing what she had said, since my own thoughts drifted. “Did you get the raspberry cake bars?” She laughed and nodded as all my attention turned to her. I had a sweet tooth, and she knew it.

“I did, Miss.”

I went over to her basket, and she swatted me away.

“Oh, just a taste, Mrs. Chaff, please.” I begged her.

“No, Miss. I can’t have you spoiling your dinner.” She told me as if I was a young child who ate too many sweets as it was and didn’t have enough self-control to stop at only one. Well, it didn’t help that I have proved that theory once or twice...maybe a dozen times.

I laughed and picked up my father's tea, putting it on a tray along with some biscuits, then made my way up to his room. Our house was large, and we had just enough maids to keep it clean and running smoothly. Even though Father was wealthy and had enough coin to run a small town, he decided to live a life that was simple. Not that I minded, in fact, I felt it gave me more freedom to explore my interests instead of having to live up to having the next best carriage or current style of gown followed by the snobbish mannerism that usually came with it. Father let me be free, even though Beth followed the more proper behavior expected of young women.

My appeal for herbs turned into a dedication to learning about the plants, and soon I volunteered at the Apothecary to feed my desire to help those around me and now, my grandmother.

I was glad it was only for a few short months that I would be away from my family. I looked around as I walked down the hall, a sense of nostalgia washing over me. These walls brought so much comfort to my life throughout my childhood.

I shook it off. I'd be back; it's not like I had any prospects. I was just leaving to help my grandmother, and I'd return before I knew it, I'd be making rounds with Healer Benton.

Making my way up the stairs and down the hall, I saw my father's room was already ajar, and voices were coming through. Trying not to eavesdrop, I thought about the upcoming trip and what I needed to prepare, only to have my name grab my attention.

"She can't go. Not my Emma. That mother of yours has no right to ask such a thing. Not after you left because of...well, you know why."

"It will only be for a few short months, Herald. She has a gift, and you know it."

"Gift? More like a curse. You know what they do to their kind, your kind!"

What was father talking about?

Your kind?

"She will be safe. Just because I did not want that path, does not mean she won't."

"I love you Martha, you know I do, but this is too much." He coughed and made a wheezing sound, and I hurried forward, pushing the door open to my parent's room.

Mother looked towards me and back to Father, who was still coughing, and she looked concerned. Father was laying up in bed with pillows behind his back for support. His white hair was short, along with his goatee that has been neglected due to his illness. He seemed to have aged overnight, and I worried for him. If he didn't get better soon, I'd have to talk with the healer to see what else I could do to help him.

"I brought your tea, father. It should help with your congestion and cough."

"Thank you, my darling. Come set the tray down right here." His voice came out wheezy as he motioned towards his bedside table.

I set the tray down and handed him the steaming cup, which he eagerly took from my hands and sipped. Once he was done, he settled back against his pillows, closed his eyes, and breathed in deeply.

"She also can't go because I need her here. No one else makes tea that calms this frustrating cough like she does." He said with his eyes still closed.

"I can make your tea just as well."

I was surprised my mother was fighting for me to go when she had refused to let me leave just a half hour ago. I wondered what changed her mind.

Father coughed again, but I could already tell the tea had helped soothe his throat since it wasn't as long or rough as it had been a few seconds ago. He settled back against the pillow and almost instantly fell asleep, his chest slowly rising. Mother pulled up the blanket to his chest and tucked him in. Her emotions were so raw as she looked at Father. Deep love, devotion, and worry were displayed on her face. She bent down and kissed his forehead and I hoped one day I would find a love like they had. It was so rare and pure. Nothing compared to it.

"Come, let us discuss your grandmother," she said, turning to me and heading out the door. I followed her into the drawing room where she went to the window and looked out its glass panes into the busy streets, her hands clasped behind her back.

Chapter 3

Sitting down on the sofa I waited patiently for her to speak, my hands in my lap as I looked towards her.

After a while, she came and knelt in front of me and clasped my hands, so many emotions flickered through her eyes.

“Emma, are you sure you want to go? Tallour is not your average town. It’s full of...mystery and...”

I wondered what she knew that I didn’t. One moment she was pressing for my departure, the next, she was unsure.

“It’s okay, Mother, I’m not afraid.” I gave her a small smile. “I believe this will be good for me. I’ll be able to take care of grandmother and use the skills I have learned from assisting Healer Benton.”

“That is not what I am worried about. I just don’t want you to change.”

“Change? How? I’ll always be Emma, ...but hopefully a little more experienced after this trip.” I was grateful she always supported my ambitions for the apothecary and my fascination for plants. In fact, on a few occasions throughout the years, she would visit me in my garden while I was tending to my plants and watch me without saying a word.

“Ever since you were little, you’ve been captivated with plants. You get that from me, you know.”

“Really, but I never see you in the garden?”

“When I was your age and before I left Tallour...” she grabbed my attention since she barely talked about growing up and her hometown. “I would help my mother in her herb garden and not only would we tend to the town, but the animals as well.”

“Grandmother is a Healer?” I exclaimed. My resolve to go solidified. Not only could I help tend to her, but I would have a constant mentor to teach me all the skills I desired once she was better.

“Of the sorts. Now Emma, Tallour is not your normal town. You have to be safe and careful. People are not what they seem and...” Then something changed in her countenance and she stood up quickly, pacing the room.

“No, what am I thinking? I couldn’t possibly let you go. It’s too dangerous and you haven’t shown any signs of...” She paused, turned to me, and looked at my hands.

I looked down at them too, but they seemed normal to me, except earlier, when they tingled. But I wouldn’t tell her that. IF she knew anything was wrong with me, she would definitely keep me here.

“No.” She stated bluntly, shaking her head, but I could tell she didn’t mean it. This was my chance to convince her.

I also wondered what horror she remembered from her old town that made her so indecisive? I knew she left for a reason, but maybe it was deeper than we all thought.

“Please, Mother,” I begged. “How different could it be from here? I am almost of age, and you know it is my dream to become a Healer. This will give me the necessary skills to prove to Healer Benton that I am qualified to be his full-time assistant.”

“I know, but you don’t know what’s out there, Emma. It’s full of things that you’ve only read in storybooks. They are not natural and shunned by the rest of the world. I just want you to be safe and live a normal life.”

“I will be safe. I promise, Mother. I’ll stay near her cottage and only go to the town for food and necessities that I need. Please.”

She stood up and headed towards the door, and before she entered the hall she looked back at me.

“I’m sorry, Emma, I should never have mentioned it. No one is going. I’ll write to her and let her know.”

“But who will take care of her?”

“She is a...she’ll be fine.”

I knew when my mother had decided on something, and there was nothing you could say to change her mind, so I nodded and watched her leave, clenching my dress in frustration. Then an idea came to me, and I rushed to my room to write a letter of my own.

Chapter 4

I woke up early the following day and quickly got dressed so I could head into town to deliver a letter I wrote to grandmother telling her I wanted to come and assist her, “*so, please send a carriage.*”

Before I headed out the door, I quietly checked on my father to see if he was getting any better. When I entered his room, I could feel the sickness penetrating the air. His skin was flushed, and beads of sweat were on his forehead. Walking over to the wash bin, I poured the cold liquid into the basin and grabbed a clean white linen cloth, dunking it in the water. After wringing it out I went over and sat at the edge of father’s bed and wiped his forehead that was burning with fever. Once I made him comfortable, I headed down to the kitchen to make him some herbal tea that would hopefully help reduce the fever before I headed out.

Ten minutes later, I placed the tea on his bedside table. I took the cloth that was now warm from his forehead, and replaced it with a cool one. He started to cough and I noticed the wheezing in his lungs was getting worse.

“How’s he doing?”

I turned to find Mother watching me in the doorway.

“He is burning with fever, but I’ve made him some tea to help.”
Pointing to the tray. She entered the room and came up beside me.

“You have such a big heart, Emma, and your talents will save many from suffering...”

Was she changing her mind about letting me go to grandmother’s? Maybe I didn’t have to send the letter. Hope filled me.

“That’s why we need you here, my darling.”

My heart sank at her words. I should have known better.

“Yes, Mother.” I nodded, then got up to leave. I hated going behind her back, but the opportunity to care and learn from someone was too great a chance for me to pass by. I would be eighteen soon and of an age where I could make my own choices. I wasn’t a child anymore and needed to spread my wings.

Why could she not see that?

“I’ll wake him up. You go and do what you need to.” My mother told me, and it was the perfect opportunity to escape.

I grabbed my dark cloak on the way out. Even though it was summer, the mornings wanted to remind us of the place we have destituted ourselves to. Another reason I wanted to leave. Tallour was south of us and no doubt warmer than Gale. My dark cloak barely kept out the chill of this forsaken place. The docks were busy and I could see father’s boats in the distance. His crew was just coming back from the sea with loads of fish to sell at the market. Pulling my hood low so no one would notice me as I walked by, only to have something catch my eye.

Beth was wrapped up in a shawl and talking with my father’s captain on the docks. Wondering why she was braving the cold when he came so frequently to our cottage as it was. I knew she had an infatuation with the man but this only confirmed my suspicions. I had to push my curiosity down since I, myself, didn’t want to be caught. Turning my head to the side, I made my way across the street.

“Emma!” I froze for a moment and debated if I should just keep walking and pretend I didn’t hear my sister calling out to me, but since I stopped, she would know that I heard her. Thinking quickly of some excuse I could tell her before she made her way over, but I came up with nothing since most of the shops were still closed and I usually volunteered at the apothecary on Thursday, and it was Wednesday.

“Emma? Is that you?”

I turned and put on my best smile. The captain was walking right behind her. He was tall with sandy blonde hair and a build that proved he worked long and hard days for my father’s incorporation

“Hello Beth, what are you doing here so early?” I questioned her with raised eyebrows. Maybe if I pointed out her own unusual predicament she wouldn’t ask me about mine. She flushed and turned to the captain, who came up beside her and placed his hand in hers. I was caught off guard by his boldness with my sister, and she turned an even deeper crimson.

“Hello, Miss Emma,” the captain gave me a smile and a small salute with the hand that was not latched onto my sisters.

“Hello, Captain. It’s a beautiful morning don’t you think?” Asking him with raised brows and then looked at my sister’s hand, hoping he understood my unspoken question, but instead of answering, he just

turned to my sister and gave her a broad smile, bringing their clasped hands to his heart.

“Yes, it is.”

She flushed again at his words and turned back to me. “Oh, Beth, I have the most wonderful news! Johnny has just proposed, and I have said yes!”

“Proposed?” I tried to keep the shock out of my voice, but her face told me I didn’t do a very good job at it, so I put on the most genuine smile I could muster and tried again.

“I’m so thrilled for you, Beth. Congratulations are in order, Captain. Do father and mother know?” I knew they didn’t, but I had to ask so they knew they had to get permission from the man who raised the daughter he wanted to marry.

“No, but please don’t tell them yet.” Then she came and grabbed my hands and continued to plead with me. “It’s one of the reasons I didn’t want to go. I was waiting for Johnny to return, and now that he has...”

He stepped forward, “I have finally saved enough funds that I can comfortably buy a home and provide for Beth while I am away at sea. She will never want for anything. Which is why I have not asked for her hand sooner since I wanted to assure your father that I could take care of her.”

All the pieces came together on why she refused the other suitors and how she acted every time the captain came to call on father. I wondered how long this has been going on, and when he did come to give my father current reports, he probably also came to see his eldest daughter. While I didn’t think they went about it the right way, I was genuinely happy for them. He was a good man and proved time and time again to be loyal and honest to my father’s business and those around him.

I squeezed her hands and looked at them both.

“I am happy for you, Beth. Both of you, I really am. No two people are better fit for each other. I won’t tell Father or Mother, but I suggest you ask them soon. With father’s health the way it is, who knows how much longer he has.”

I know we have been hoping for Father to get better, but working with the healer for so long and attending to so many sick people made me nervous he might not. Those thoughts brought me back to the letter that was stowed away deep in my cloak pocket that I was going to deliver to

grandmother. Its contents told her I anticipated coming to be her companion for a time.

Realization dawned on me. I couldn't leave now, not with father's illness and now Beth's engagement. I was needed here, no matter how much I wanted to go. I decided I would burn the letter when I got home.

"You're right." Then she turned to the captain. "Let's go see my father today."

"I think that is a wonderful idea." He replied and pulled her close.

Beth then looked at me as if she realized who I really was. "Why are you here, Emma? Are you heading to the Apothecary?"

"Something like that, but I am done now and was heading home."

"Well, come with us. That way we can celebrate together once father has blessed our engagement."

"That sounds wonderful."

Beth linked one arm with me and the other with the captain before we headed down the docks towards our comfy cottage, grateful we wouldn't be in this cold weather for much longer. Beth and the captain continued conversing about their future days together, so I tuned them out as we walked.

Suddenly, out of nowhere, a large crow swept down in front of us, and perched on the carpenter's sign above us. It was the largest crow I have ever seen and a rarity in these parts. We mostly had seagulls here in Gale since we were surrounded by the sea. I slipped my hand out of my sister's hold to get a better look at the magnificent black bird. They kept walking, so caught up in their planning that they didn't notice I fell behind or that there was now a large, rare bird watching us.

The crow stared back with its beady eyes, tilting its head side to side as if observing me.

Kaw! Kaw! It screeched, then spread out its wings and lifted into the air. I watched it for a minute as it flew away into the distance.

"Emma!" My sister called to me.

"Coming!"

Chapter 5

We finally made it home, and I was grateful the sun was starting to warm up the air. So, I excused myself to attend to my garden while they went and talked to Father.

I opened the black iron gate that surrounded the many herbs, roots, and vegetables that I grew and made my way over to the herb patch. Peppermint, basil, sage, rosemary, and thyme were only a few of what I had planted this year. I noticed the peppermint was not growing as well as it usually did and it concerned me since I was running low on my personal supply. I bent down and rubbed the brown leaves in my hand, wondering what I could do to help them thrive. I know living in Gale didn't help with the colder climate, but they grew well last year so I wondered what had changed.

Kaw!

I turned at the sound and saw the same crow from town now perched on the fence right next to me. It fluttered its ebony wings, its feathers shining in the morning sun, then it settled down between the iron post that stuck out and tilted its head again as if it was studying me. I hoped it wasn't waiting for me to leave so it could pick at my garden.

"Don't go pecking at my garden now. Okay, crow. I worked hard to grow these herbs and vegetables." I felt silly talking to the bird but then it bobbed its head up and down as if it understood me.

I blinked, thinking I imagined it, then shook my head and continued running my hands through my herbs to see if any more were dying. Luckily, there were only a few spots, so I cleared the decayed plants and pulled some weeds to pass the time until Beth came out to tell me the exciting news that Father was going to bless their future marriage.

"Can you believe it? I'm getting married!" She exclaimed.

I gave her a hug, careful not to get dirt on her. "I'm so happy for you. I knew he would approve."

"Oh, Emma, if only the same thing could happen to you."

I laughed, “I think I’m best suited in the garden,” pointing to my rows of vegetation. I couldn’t imagine being trapped in wedlock when my garden called to me.

She gave me a look, letting me know I might change my mind one day, but I doubted it.

I clasped her hands, “but you, you’ve prepared your whole life for this and will make a beautiful bride.”

She smiled, forgetting my indifference to marriage. “Oh, it’s truly a dream come true! I’ll leave you to your herbs, since there is so much to prepare.”

She ran back inside, and I could see Johnny in the hallway talking to my Mother, who seemed just as happy as my sister about the news.

I sighed, thinking of her words, but I knew most men wanted their wives dolled up and ready to hang off their arms for display. Not running around with dirt on their hands, cooking up concoctions to heal the sick.

Kaw! Kaw!

The sound brought me out of my thoughts as I looked to the fence. I almost forgot the crow was there, since I became so engrossed with my sister and the task before me. My mother often told me that nothing could keep me from my garden, and I was deaf to the world when I was tending to it. She was right.

The crow tilted its head one more time before it shot into the air and flew south. I watched it until it was a tiny speck in the sky, wondering if I would ever see it again.

“Hmmm. How unusual.” I mumbled to myself.

An hour passed as I carefully tended to each plant, giving them the care they deserved.

They didn’t care if my hands were covered in dirt.

I heard a crash, and saw Beth flinging open the gate to my garden. Her face was distressed, and I wondered what had happened.

“Did Johnny change his mind?” I stepped towards her, but right as I said those words, my heart told me it was something else.

My heart pounded as she shook her head, confirming my fears.

“It’s Father. He was fine an hour ago, but...”

“No!” I gasped, dropping my basket, making my vegetables and herbs spill everywhere, but I didn’t care. I rushed past her into the house, up the stairs to my father's bedroom. When I arrived, the captain stood outside the door with his head hung low. He looked up when he heard my footsteps and stepped towards me.

“I’m sorry, Emma. He was such a great man. I’m so sorry.”

No. He was wrong. Father was alive. I pushed past him and entered my parents room to see mother kneeling next to father, her head on his chest. Her shoulders shook from her grief as a stream of tears went down her face, mine soon following.

“No... No! ...No!!!” I shook my head, looking at the pale face of my father. I rushed to him, my heart breaking for the man who raised me, who loved his daughters and wife unconditionally, and who provided a life of comfort for them. He couldn’t be gone, not after I tried so hard to help him get better. I’ve seen so much sickness and death over the years working with the healer, but nothing felt as hollow or as surreal as what was happening before me. Nothing prepared me to lose someone who was so close to me. Who loved and always encouraged me to follow my heart, especially when I chose to follow a different path, when I expressed interest in being a healer. Even though women were scarcely such a thing, he supported me until his dying breath.

My shoulders shook as I came up to Mother and placed a hand on her shoulder. She sat up and pulled me into a hug.

“Oh, Emma, how could he be taken from us so soon?”

I had no words for her as I returned her embrace, wondering the same thing myself. How could a man who has done so much good for our town, his family, and everyone he met, be taken from this earth far before his time? Where was the justice in that?

“I don’t know mother...I don’t know.”

Mother turned and reached a hand out and motioned for Beth, who had just entered the room, to come closer. She pulled us both in a tight embrace as we mourned our loss.

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Chapter 6

A month had passed since my father's funeral. We were still wearing our black apparel out of respect for the departed. We were currently waiting for the solicitor to come and read us our father's will. Mother was putting it off because we had nowhere to go and was worried about where our assets and father's business would end up.

A loud knock came from the front door and Mother motioned for me to answer. We were all sitting in the drawing room, including Johnny, waiting for the inevitable.

"Please answer the door, dear, we've been putting this off long enough."

I nodded and went to the door to open up to find a short man with brown hair slicked back. His attire was pressed and perfect.

"Hello, Miss, is this the Bedford residency?"

"Yes."

"I'm Solicitor Jones, and I've come to read your father's will."

"Yes, please, do come in," I told him and I made my way to the side and motioned for him to step through. I led him to the drawing room where everyone was waiting for the inevitable. Mother stood up and made her way towards the solicitor when we entered.

"Good morning, Solicitor Jones. Please, come in and sit." She motioned towards the settee. He sat down in a stiff manner and opened a leather case that he held in his hand, pulling out a thick letter that was sealed with red wax.

The man got straight to the point. No condolences or nothing of the sort as if death was just another day and it irked me.

My Father did so much for this town, but I kept my silence and awaited our fate.

"Mr. Edward Trent Bedford, who passed away on June 3, 1712, left a will for his wife, Sharon Lilly Bedford, and his daughters. The will was revised on May 15th, 1712."

He showed us the will and seal. Mother nodded for him to proceed. After breaking the seal, he went on to read the words that would no doubt change our lives forever. He said it was revised so recently and I

wonder if father knew he was not going to make it. My heart clenched at him knowing that reality, but I was grateful he made sure things were in order before he passed.

“...the house, which is paid in full, will be left to my wife, Sharon Lily Bedford, and will receive all assets, shareholder rights and ownership to my business Bedford Inc...”

“...Daughters will each receive a large dowry of five thousand pounds, either upon marriage or their twenty-fifth birthday, whichever comes first...”

He continued to go over the small details, but our hearts were relieved that he left the house to Mother, and that we would not be left destitute on the streets.

“Here is a copy of the will.” He reached into his parcel, pulled out another thick letter, and handed it to Mother. Her brows furrowed, and I wondered what was bothering her.

“Solicitor Jones, since my husband left me ownership of his business, does that make me eligible to do with it as I will?”

Worry overcame me, and I wondered what she meant by her words.

“Yes.”

Then she looked towards Beth and Johnny. “Captain, I know you love my daughter and have put off your engagement and marriage due to the unfortunate circumstances that have befallen us. You are a good man, and I know you will take care of her and her family.”

Then, she turned back to the solicitor. “I would like have Johnny Stalwart as my main business partner and overseer of Bedford Inc. He will have equal rights and authority in our partnership and legal rights to do with the business as he sees fit. We will work out the details later, but if it is possible, I would like the amends to be effective immediately.”

Beth gasped and Johnny’s eyes were wide as they stared at Mother in disbelief.

“Oh, Mother!” Beth cried and rushed to give her a hug and Johnny stood up and embraced her too.

“I...I don’t know what to say.” Johnny stumbled as shock overcame him.

“Nothing, just take care of my daughter...” Then she smiled, “partner.”

“She will never want for anything, and neither will you. I will see that she is well taken care of and...”

Mother laughed aloud and hugged the poor man who was so taken back by this generous offer. “I know you will Johnny, that is why I am doing this. Plus, I am not fit to run a business that is so well taken care of by you already.”

“I am honored by your words. Thank you.” He bowed over her hand.

Mother turned back to the solicitor, “That is all I have for now. Thank you so much for your time.”

“Your welcome, Madam Bedford. I will write up the proper papers and bring them by within the next week to have them signed.”

Mother asked me to show the man to the door and my heart was full that I would not be leaving the home that had so many cherished memories it held within its walls. Making my way back to the drawing room, I heard Beth and Mother discussing the upcoming wedding.

“Are you sure, Mother?”

“Yes, there is no sense in waiting. Your father has taken care of us and I know your heart longs to be married to this good man beside you.”

“Oh, Mother. Thank you.”

I stepped into the room, and everyone looked at me. Beth and mother both had tears of joy in their eyes and Johnny was glowing with pride at the fortunate situation.

Beth ran up to me and clasped my hands in hers. “Oh, Emma. Mother has just blessed our marriage to happen sooner than later. Who knew this day could turn out to be so glorious.”

“I’m so happy for you. You will make the most darling captain’s wife.”

“Thank you, Emma. When he’s away, I will come and visit, and it will be just like old times.”

I smiled at her. “I look forward to it.”

We discussed the wedding plans the rest of the morning until we took a midday break. The captain excused himself since he had to head back to the docks and see to his men. I made my way out to the garden, thinking over the day’s events and the dowry. I just turned eighteen last week and if I had the money now, instead of when I married or turned twenty-five, I could probably open my own apothecary with the funds that

were allotted, and since I had no man pining for my hand at the moment, it would seem the only option was to wait until I was on the brink of spinsterhood. A sigh left me as I opened the backdoor to the kitchen and made my way out to the herb garden I have neglected over the past month.

Kaw! Kaw!

My head whipped around to see the same large crow, perched in the same spot on the fence that it was over a month ago. Just as before, it tilted its head, and I swear I could see a deep intelligence behind its black beady eyes, more than the average bird.

“Well, hello there. It seems you have returned. Not picking at my garden, are we?” I pretended to scold my black feathered friend.

Kaw!

I laughed as he ruffled his feathers and turned as if offended by my words.

“I’m sorry. I know you would not do such a thing. Not that I have done much for my garden this past month.”

I looked at the overgrown patch of weeds that surrounded my herbs and sighed. I knelt down to start pulling the wretched weeds that took over my sanctuary. A tingling feeling went straight to my hands as I plunged in the dirt. It didn’t hurt, but the sensation took me off guard once more. I looked at the bird, wondering if it noticed.

Kaw! Kaw!

I was being ridiculous, it was just a crow.

“I know. I know. It’s not as if I had time.”

The bird looked sad, if that was possible. As if he understood all that my heart was feeling and how broken it has been since my father’s passing.

Then he opened his wings, and I wondered if he was going to leave, but he did something that surprised me. He flew off the fence and landed right in front of me. I pulled back, and it hopped forward until it was close to my hand, looking at me while tilting its head to the side as if asking if I was okay.

“I’m fine.” I told the bird, almost choking on my words. After a few seconds, the crow slowly lowered its head and rubbed the top of my fingers in a loving manner. I was surprised at the comfort I felt at the gesture. I turned my fingers over to scratch under its chin, but he hopped back and flew to the same spot on the fence post.

I turned my body and looked at the bird and whispered, “Thank you.”

Kaw. He quietly responded, and I knew he understood.

For the next half hour, I pulled the weeds as he watched me in companionable silence. Grateful that tingly sensation didn’t come back. This was the second time it had happened and I wondered if my hands were tired or if it was something else. Pushing my worries down, I continued pulling the weeds.

Once I moved from my peppermint to the basil, I looked back to make sure I didn’t miss anything. I noticed the leaves that were dying on the plant were now freshly green and flourishing. I looked to the crow and back to the plant. That couldn’t be possible. It usually took up to a week to get my neglected plants to be where they were formally, not a few minutes. I shook my head, realizing I must be more tired than I thought. I told myself that once I was done weeding, I would go inside and take a nap.

Time continued as I pulled the weeds and was surprised the crow stayed to watch me. One time, I tried to throw him some seeds to eat but the look he gave me made me laugh, and I didn’t try again.

I pushed off my knees to my feet once I was done and turned to the crow to tell him I’d see him later but found he was gone. My heart sank. He gave me comfort that I didn’t know I needed and I looked around the garden wondering if he was sitting on a different post. When he was nowhere to be found, I brushed myself off, hoping I didn’t ruin the dress I was wearing since two spots of dirt were now visible where I was kneeling. Before entering the kitchen I washed up by the pump, and decided to fill up some buckets for the cook while I was at it.

I made my way to the kitchen door, looking back once more to see if the crow was still there, but that is not what grabbed my attention. My garden was beautiful, green, and thriving as if I had never neglected it. I looked at my hands and wondered how the miracle had happened and if the crow had anything to do with it.

Hoping I wasn’t losing my mind I entered the kitchen and put the buckets on the counter for the cook and made my way out into the hall and to my room for a much needed rest.

“Emma. Please come here.” I turned and saw my mother standing by herself in the middle of the drawing room holding a piece of clothing made of a deep crimson material.

Entering the drawing room, I looked around to see if Beth and Johnny were still here.

“Johnny went back to the docks, and your sister is upstairs planning her wedding.”

Then she took a deep sigh, that was different from sadness, but more of a resolve, and I wondered what was on her mind. Then she took the piece of clothing from her arms and held it up to me.

It was the most beautiful cloak I have ever seen and the workmanship was beyond comparison. It was even trimmed with an intricate silver design.

“Oh, Mother, it is beautiful.” I ran up to her, touching the soft thick material and running my fingers over the silver edging.

“It’s yours. A parting gift from me to you.”

“Parting? What do you mean?” Was she sending me away? Would she not receive enough funds to support me, even though her oldest daughter would be taken care of? Maybe I should talk to Healer Benton now to see if he would take me on as a paid assistant.

“Is it the funds? I can see if Healer...”

“No, darling, I am not sending you away. Well...sort of.”

“I don’t understand?”

She set the cloak across the settee and came up to grab my hands. I almost pulled back but waited to see what she had to say.

“I have written to your grandmother and have decided you can go and learn all you can from her.”

“Really?”

“Yes. I can no longer keep you from the talents that I know you carry.” She seemed like she wanted to say more, so I anticipated her next words, but she turned and grabbed the cloak and held it up for me to try on.

It was thick, warm, and absolutely beautiful. It had a hood that was double lined with wool to keep out the cold. I swished it back and forth to look at the intricate design that lined the edges, then rushed to give my mother a hug.

“It’s beautiful, Mother. Thank you so much.”

“It will keep you warm on the coldest of days. Tallour might be warmer than here, but it still gets a bitter chill in the winter.”

My heart sank. “Mother, but what about you? Beth will be married and you’ll have no one to keep you company.”

As much as I wanted to go, I could not abandon my mother.

“Nonsense, I have a business to help run, luckily I’ll get a son-in-law who knows the ins and outs of it.” She smiled at me reassuringly.

“Yes, but to stay here in this house by yourself.”

“Nonsense Emma. The maids will keep me company.” Then she grabbed me in a fierce hug, and her voice choked on her next words, and I couldn’t help the tears that streamed down her face.

“You cannot reach your full potential as a healer staying in Gale, Emma. You have so much to offer, and I know this is the best decision, no matter how hard it is. Know that I will always love you.”

“Of course, Mother, I love you too. Nothing will ever change that, no matter how far I go.”

“It’s settled then.” Then she pushed off of me and grabbed my shoulders. “A stagecoach will arrive in three weeks. Just enough time to get Beth married and say our goodbyes.”

I nodded, knowing if I spoke, only tears would come. I was excited for this new adventure but also sad to leave my mother and sister behind. No matter how much they were taken care of, this was my home. The place I grew up and had my most cherished memories, but I knew the opportunity to improve my skills was something I could not pass up.

I headed up to my room to ponder how much my life has changed in such a short amount of time and hoped that I was making the right choice.

Chapter 7

The stagecoach bustled back and forth, making my body sway with its movements. It picked me up early this morning, right on schedule. My trunks were latched to the top of the carriage, and the only thing I had with me was my current cross-stitch project and my red cloak that Mother gave me. It was chilly this morning, even though it was summer. Rain was drizzling down from the sky, which made it perfect for wearing the beautiful gift my mother bestowed upon me. The weather was as if Gale was giving me its last goodbye.

Its drops hid my own tears as I said goodbye to my mother, sister, and her new husband.

We were just passing the border of Gale when I heard a familiar sound.

Kaw!

Opening the curtain that covered the window, I saw the black crow swoosh by and land on a tree in the distance. I waved the bird goodbye, sad that I would never see him again. We've become friends over the last couple weeks as I tended to my garden. He would sometimes come by and watch me, but never got close like he did that one time. He would just sit on his post and sometimes fall asleep while I worked. Then when I got up he would sound a goodbye and fly away. It was as if seeing him let the reality of it all sink in and tears flowed down my cheeks, grateful that no one occupied the carriage just yet. It was a five day trip, so I was sure we would get some passengers along the way, but for now, I would be grateful for the solitude that allowed me to cry in peace. I know it was only for a few months that I would be in Tallour and away from my family. Mother said it might be longer and to take all the time I needed to learn all that I could from grandmother, but I couldn't stay away for too long. This was my home.

I closed the curtains and settled back against the plush seats, and thought about all that has happened in the last three weeks. Beth got married last week, and the few weeks before, we prepared tirelessly for the wedding, which was small but beautiful. We used most of the flowers from my garden and I was surprised at how many bloomed the day before the wedding. It was as if I owned a greenhouse for flowers instead of my small garden patch. Two days before the event, I went out to take notes and see what we could use. I had a few rose bushes along the edge, daisies, foxgloves, yarrow, marigold, St. John's Wort, lavender, and feverfew. The blooms were sparse between each plant since I didn't need too many for my own collection, but I was sad there were barely enough to make a beautiful bouquet for my sister on her special day.

I remember kneeling down and pulling some weeds so they wouldn't choke the plants already in bloom. My fingers tingled once again, just like they did a week before. It was as if power was flowing out of me and into the plants. I pulled back and looked at my hands wondering why they would sometimes do that, but I couldn't deny how frightened I became when I saw the plants starting to grow before me and flowers of unusual quantity sprang open right before my eyes. I got up quickly and ran to my room, scared at what I had just witnessed. It was as if I had magic that helped the flowers bloom, but that was impossible. Magic wasn't real, and I was just an ordinary girl who loved her herbs. Those who claimed to have magic were shunned, rejected, and treated with disdain as if they were evil itself, but not me, I was a good girl and I was being ridiculous.

I ended up brushing it off, saying my exhaustion at the last few months had finally caught up to me, and I must have been hallucinating.

I took a long nap, and woke up feeling as normal as before.

Early the next morning, when I went to gather the flowers to make my sister's bouquet, and my garden was so full of flowers, it choked my other plants. I noticed they were hanging over my fence and climbing up the brick wall of our house. I could barely make my way through the dense greenery to pick the flowers to start decorating for my sister's wedding. Upon closer inspection, I noticed they not only had quantity, but the flowers were the most vibrant I've ever seen. Their beautiful aroma filled the air around me, and I breathed it in deeply. I ended up picking enough flowers,

not only for her bouquet but to help decorate the church, an arch, and a flower crown for her to wear. It was the most beautifully decorated wedding I have ever been to, and I was grateful for my little garden and the blessing it gave me to give my sister one last gift before I left Gale.

I looked back down at my hands as the carriage continued to sway back and forth, wondering if they would tingle again, but I felt nothing out of the ordinary. A sigh left my lips. It was so strange how my garden was reacting to me, and it was only after my eighteenth birthday that the tingling sensation started happening. Maybe I was aging faster than I thought, and a good herbal tonic would be just the trick to get me right back on my feet, but it still didn't explain the plants growing right before my eyes. Maybe, I could ask my grandmother about it since she was a healer as well and no doubt worked with plants. It was probably normal, and I was just overreacting.

Satisfied with my reasoning for now, I continued my cross-stitching to pass the time. It was only the first day of our journey, and I should be using the time to fill my mind with knowledge, not superstitious things like magic. Eventually, my eyes became heavy and I fell asleep, leaning my head against the plush-covered walls of the carriage as I swayed into dreams full of magic and flowers.

I woke up with a start when we hit a large bump in the road. My body swayed to the other side of the carriage, and I caught myself just in time, only to be jerked back to the other side.

I waited for the driver to let me know what was going on and noticed the carriage start to slow.

Once we reached a stop, I noticed my cross-stitching was now on the floor, so I went to pick it up right as the door swung open.

"You alright, Miss?" The driver asked as he poked his head inside the carriage. He was an older gentleman with a full dark beard and an eyepatch that covered his left eye.

"Yes. Is everything alright out there?"

"We hit a large rock, and it cracked one of the wheels. If you don't mind waiting just outside, we'll have it fixed straight away and be back on

the road before you know it.”

Grabbing my cloak, I exited the carriage and realized the sun was starting to set. I must have dozed off longer than I thought since it was getting dark already. It didn't help that we were surrounded by thick trees that made up the forest around us and blocked out most of the sun's rays. A shiver went through me from the cold forest air and I put my cloak on as I watched the men fix the carriage from the edge of the forest.

A growl came from behind me, and I whipped around to see what animal was nearby, my heart pounding in my chest. My eyes scanned the forest as I slowly moved backwards towards the carriage and the men fixing it, not wanting to make any sudden moves. I heard another low growl and it sounded closer than the previous one, and the largest wolf I have ever seen stepped out from behind a tree.

It was black as night and its yellow eyes were staring straight at me, with its fangs bared. It took another step towards me and gave another low growl. Fear shook me as I realized just how large it was. My head would barely reach this animal...no, this monster's shoulders. I tried to scream to warn the men, hoping they had some form of weapon or gun on them, but my body froze, and shock overtook me. The only thing I could do was open my mouth and say a silent prayer that my life would be spared.

KAW! KAW! KAW!

It was as if heaven answered my prayer when a blur of black swooped down in front of me, and I recognized my rescuer immediately.

The large crow started pecking at the wolf, screeching a battle cry that agitated the wolf. Fear for the crow's safety brought me to my senses, and I wanted to call him away. I looked around for a big stick that I could use to help as the wolf started snapping at the bird, but to my great relief, missed every time. Then the crow flew into the forest, and the wolf bounded after the animal.

“No!” I started to step towards the forest as fear for my friend's life took over me, my courage now returning.

“Everything alright, Miss Bedford?”

I turned and looked at the stagecoach driver and back to the forest. Did he not see the wolf that was there? How could they have missed it?

Why did they not come to help!

“There was a wolf! Didn’t you see it?” I pointed to the forest.

“No, Miss,” his eyes went wide with worry as he scanned the forest, everything was silent; not even the sound of squawking filled the air, and I worried the wolf had gotten my little friend.

Tears sprang to my eyes, but I blinked them away. He wasn’t dead. He couldn’t be.

I watched the forest for a few more moments, waiting for the bird to fly into the air and prove my heart's desire, but the sky stayed barren.

“Best get you inside the carriage if there are wolves.” The driver quickly waved me forward, but I could tell he thought I was a little strange for claiming there was a wolf when clearly there was nothing there.

Guilt filled me for leaving my winged hero behind, not knowing if he was safe or not.

I looked to the forest again, hoping he would pop up and let me know he was alive.

“It isn’t safe to stay out here, and the wheels are all fixed anyway, so we’re ready to head out.” The driver said with slight frustration when I didn’t move, as if I was vying for attention like some simpering Miss.

But I knew what I saw and didn’t try to defend myself.

I let out a sigh and moved towards the carriage, where he was holding the door open for me. I climbed in, and once the carriage started to move, I opened the window curtain to look once more at the spot where I saw the monstrous wolf. Sending a silent prayer to the heavens that my winged friend would be alright.

The next few days were quiet and lonely since we didn’t pick up any passengers. We stopped a few times to change horses and rest, only to begin again. I was grateful for the times we did stop so I could stretch out my legs and get my blood flowing again.

On the fourth day, we stopped at a large town called Camer, which was our last stop before Tallour. We would arrive at my grandmother's town the next morning and I was eager to be free of these four rattling walls that felt more like a cage now.

A robust older woman entered the carriage with a large black feathered hat that only reminded me of my winged friend that saved me from the wolf a couple of days ago. I wondered if she was in mourning since her gown was black as well; which reminded me of my Father and my heart ached even more.

She sat on the opposite side of the carriage and fixed her dress. Then took off her hat, which showed her gray hair with white streaks on the side that knotted into a bun at the nape of her neck. Then she looked at me as if she just realized I was there, not that I was surprised, most people in Gale only knew me because I worked with the healer and was the daughter of the town's wealthiest merchant. Otherwise, no one gave me much attention, especially the young men who came to see my father. They all had eyes for Beth, who was now married. My heart clenched realizing how far I was away from home.

"What's a young miss like you doing so far from home?" Her words only solidified my remorse. "Surely, your parents wouldn't send you about roaming the country! How irresponsible of them!" She scolded me, and I bit back the retort on my lips. She knew nothing of me and what I went through in the last couple of months.

"Well, girl...speak up!" She scolded me when I didn't respond right away.

My eyes went wide at the gall of this woman. She had no business prying into my affairs. While I was usually one to bite my tongue and be submissive, I could not let this woman talk ill of my family. I took a deep breath to calm my nerves before replying.

"My father passed away from an illness, and I am off to see my grandmother in Tallour to learn the trade of healing."

"Tallour! That wretched place is cursed. People have gone missing recently and I wouldn't dare step one foot in that town. Demons,

monsters, and dark magic that would make your blood boil! You better just go back home and save yourself the trouble. Nothing ever good came from Tallour.”

Missing people!

While I didn’t appreciate her abrasiveness, I wasn’t so prideful as to not listen to her warning. Maybe, I should turn back and head home. I knew Mother ran away from her home in Tallour when she became of age, but maybe there was more she wasn’t telling me. I shook those thoughts away; Mother would never put me in a dangerous position and send me to an unfamiliar place if she thought my life was at risk. Maybe this woman was just trying to scare me, she seemed like the type to exaggerate.

“I’ll be fine. Thank you for your concern.” I turned my head, letting her know I was done with the conversation, and picked up the cross-stitching that I placed on the bench beside me. I didn’t want to be rude, but I also didn’t want to have the rest of my trip filled with this woman’s nonsense.

“Hmph! Suit yourself, but don’t say I didn’t warn you.” Then she turned to look out her own window, and an uncomfortable silence filled the space in our confined carriage.

I couldn’t deny her words edged their way into my heart as the silence drifted on. I hoped I was doing the right thing. It was too late to turn back now. If Tallour was filled with the things this woman mentioned, I could always write to my mother to have her send a carriage to return me home, but then I would lose the opportunity to learn from my grandmother, and that is what I wanted more than anything. A sense of determination filled me, and I pushed my doubts and fears down. I wouldn’t let this woman, or anyone, deter me from what I have worked so hard to become. I would help those who lived in Tallour and aid anyone who needed me. It was what I was born to do. My father supported me until his dying breath, and my mother sent me here so that I could live up to my potential as a healer.

With those thoughts I pushed my needle into the material to finish the crow I added a few days ago to my threaded picture. He flew above the forest in the blue sky I stitched. The bottom had flowers and herbs, but there

was a space I still had to fill on the left of my cotton canvas, but I hadn't decided what animal to place there yet. I thought of a deer, but I wanted something meaningful, which was why I added my winged friend. For the next few hours, I worked on my picture until my hands got tired from pulling the thread in and out repeatedly.

I took out one of my medicinal herbs books and studied it since tomorrow the real work would begin.

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Chapter 8

We were just outside the town of Tallour, and I watched out the window as we made our way towards the shops and houses that made up this town. It was larger than I thought and it seemed everyone was buying and selling goods like any normal town.

It wasn't until the carriage creaked right past them, that I noticed they would stop and stare with wide eyes, fear penetrating their countenance, that I became worried.

"Strange people they are," I turned at the older woman's words, breaking our long impending silence.

Instead of disagreeing, a burning urge to defend them rose up inside of me.

"They are just like everyone else."

"Hmph!" She pursed her lips at my reply and turned away from me. "Don't say I didn't warn you."

I closed the curtain and leaned back against the seat, hoping I made the right choice and that the town would welcome me as an assistant to my grandmother. I would try to gain their trust and show I was worthy to help heal any ailment that befell them.

I would treat them just as I treated those back in Gale.

A few more minutes passed until the carriage stopped, and I took a deep breath.

We arrived.

The door of the carriage swung open and I quickly made my way down the steps, eager to get away from the older woman, only to be stopped

short.

Right outside the carriage was the spitting image of my mother, only her youth was gone and lines etched her face from living a full life. She was standing in front of a beautiful cottage wearing a dark gown with a shawl around her shoulders. Her red hair was streaked with white and pulled into a bun at the nape of her neck, and her smile was friendly as she held open her arms and invited me in for an embrace. I made my way towards her, and she pulled me in tightly and I immediately felt a connection with her.

“Oh, it is so good to have you here, my dear. I was hoping your mother would send you.” She released me and looked me over, her eyes twinkling with adoration.

“Really?”

“Yes.” She grinned from ear to ear and I knew I made the right choice.

“Put her bags on the porch, we’ll take it from here, Leonard.” She told the stagecoach driver. I realized I never got the man’s name the whole trip and embarrassment filled me that I did not ask him before.

“Thank you, Mr. Leonard,” I called back to him once he finished his task. He dipped his hat and hopped back onto the carriage.

“He often stops through these parts to give me salves and ingredients I’ve ordered that I can’t find in this part of Tallour.”

It made me feel better that she knew him due to familiarity and not just from a few moments ago. The carriage lurched forward and I turned to watch it leave, when I noticed the curtain was open and the older woman was glaring at me shaking her head. I turned to grandmother to see if she noticed and found her waving and smiling at the older woman, which only made her glare deepen. I held back a laugh. I knew I was going to like it here already.

“Come dear, let us get you settled in and leave the old bat to herself. It would seem old suspicions and myths of our town will never die.”

“Old suspicions?” Was the old lady right, that this town was to be avoided? All humor left me and was replaced with worry. I’ve found that myths and suspicions often hold some form of truth, no matter how small.

“Oh, nothing to worry your head over. I’m so glad you are here. These old bones can’t keep up with the work like they used to, and I will be glad to have your help.”

“I’m so glad to assist in any way I can. My mother also mentioned you would be able to teach me all about being a healer.” I couldn’t contain my desperation to know when we would start or if she was even willing to teach me, and suspicions about the town disappeared from my mind.

She turned to me with crinkly eyes and a knowing grin, “I think you have already started your path, my dear.” Then she grabbed my hands and studied them. I wondered what she was looking for. Then she patted them.

“Just as I suspected.” Then she turned back around to walk through the tall open gate that surrounded her house.

“Suspected what?” I called after her, but she just waved me forward to follow her.

When we entered, I noticed the place was full of herbs, flowers, and every kind of plant imaginable. They were green and flourishing like I have never seen before. My gaze roamed over the entire area and I noticed certain herbs were grouped that held similar healing properties. I couldn’t wait to explore the garden before me since I also saw many plants I didn’t recognize.

“It seems my garden has captured your attention.”

I looked towards my grandmother and ducked my head with embarrassment at being caught gaping.

“Yes, it’s the most beautiful and thriving garden I have ever seen.” Then excitement took over. “I’ve noticed you put certain herbs together with similar healing properties, that’s wise, and I’ve seemed to have learned something already.”

She chuckled. "I'm glad." Then she turned to me, "I can tell we are going to get along just fine."

I smiled and gave her another hug. "Oh, grandmother, I am so glad to be here!"

"Me too! You can call me Granny Tully, everyone does around here." I smiled and nodded at her.

Kaw! Kaw!

Turning to the sound that brought so much relief to my soul, I saw my friend swoop down from the sky.

"You're alive!" I called to my winged friend as he flew closer, only to land on grandmother's shoulder. My eyes went wide with surprise.

"He's yours?" I asked, baffled.

Grandmother laughed, "Yes, and it seems Tefyus is glad you are here, too." She scratched under the crow's chin, and he rubbed his head against her fingers in an affectionate manner as he chirped in agreement.

"Tefyus?"

"Yes, I had him watch over you and your journey."

Grandmother had sent him? I wondered if I should tell her that he saved me from a wolf, but I decided to tell her later and not ruin our first meeting with life-death experiences.

"May I?"

Grandmother nodded towards me, and I reached out towards the crow with my fingers. He leaned forward and rubbed my finger with his head, then lifted up into the air once more and made his way towards the cottage, which I noticed had an enchanting feel to it.

She led me down the path and to the front door. Everything looked well taken care of, and the inside was immaculately clean and orderly, just like Healer Benton's apothecary back home. I wondered where she kept her herbs and if she had a separate room for those who are sick or injured.

“I can see the wheels spinning in your mind with all the questions you have for me, but first, tea!”

She walked down the hall at a slower pace and I noticed she had a slight limp. I wondered if it was just age or if it was something else that had happened. Knowing I was here not only to learn but to be a companion for her, I would do the best of both and prove my worth to her.

We entered a large kitchen, half of it was set up for cooking while the other half had shelves upon shelves with bottles of dried-up herbs all labeled and orderly, along with multiple jars that no doubt had salves and medicines placed inside them. I noticed Tefyus was sitting on a wooden stand next to a large window with his head bent and eyes closed as if he was asleep. Glad my friend would be here for good and I didn’t have to worry about him any longer. My eyes continued to roam the room and I noticed a room with no door attached to the kitchen that had a few beds inside with clean linen sheets and a blanket folded at the end. This must be where she tends to those who come to her with ailments or injuries.

“Come, sit. There will be plenty of time to explore later, my dear. First, I want to know all about my granddaughter.” She patted the seat next to her by the wooden table. I took my cloak off and placed it on the back of the chair and sat down, wondering what she wanted to know. My life was similar to hers in a sense. I wanted to be a healer just like her and nothing too exciting ever happened outside of that.

“You’ve just turned eighteen, correct?”

“Yes, just a few weeks ago.”

“Ah, a special age for a healer. Especially for the woman in the Garretson lineage.”

“Is that our family name?” Mother never talked about her life previously, and I don’t ever recall her telling us her maiden name.

“Yes. We have a whole line of healers that dates back hundreds of years. But not just any healers, mind you. We have a gift that not many have.”

“Really? Like what?” I asked, scooting closer to her, my curiosity getting the better of me. I realized I could come off as rude, but grateful she just chuckled at my enthusiasm. Right as she was about to tell me, the

teapot whistled. She got up to make our tea while I patiently waited for her to tell me more about the gift. After our cups were filled, and the herbs were seeping, she finally continued.

“This gift allows us to help those around us, and I hope to help you nurture its magic while you are here.” She told me seriously, so different from her cheerful manner previously.

“Magic?”

“Yes. It is a gift that is given once a woman of our lineage turns eighteen to help those around them, especially in healing.”

I thought back to the last couple weeks when my hands tingled and my plants grew right before my eyes. *Was this the magic she was talking about?* I thought as I looked at my hands turning them back and forth.

“Tell me what happened?” She asked me softly, but I had a feeling she already knew.

“The day before my sister got married I went out to my garden and...” I finished telling her about how I was looking for flowers to help make her a bouquet with my hands tingling. “It felt as if power was pouring out of me, and it seemed the flowers were growing right before my eyes. Then the next morning my whole garden was full of flowers and we had more than enough for the occasion.”

I was expecting her to look shocked, but a soft smile came over her, and she grabbed my hands once more.

“Your gift is strong Emma, and I know you are going to do great things.”

I recalled my mother saying the same thing before I left. Did she have the gift too? She must have. I wondered if that is why she left. I tucked that question away for later since I wanted to know the answers to my question first.

“So, it wasn’t my imagination?” I needed her to confirm that I wasn’t delusional or crazy...maybe both.

“No. But keep your gift to yourself for now, since there are people who cannot be trusted and will use you for your powers. You’ll know in time who you can trust, but for now, let us just work on nurturing your gift.”

I nodded to her, understanding that it was not something you shared with just anyone. People were already suspicious of this town, and I

didn't want to add to that.

"Wonderful!" She was back to her cheerful self. She changed the subject to asking about the wedding, and I told her how beautiful Beth looked in her long, flowy white gown, with her hair pinned up halfway and a flower crown that made her look angelic.

"Oh, I wish I could have been there. Maybe, while you're here, you'll find your own young man." She smiled at me.

I flushed. I knew I was no beauty like my sister and had not had the chance for many suitors, not that many men would want to marry a woman who was destined to be a healer. They wanted their women at home, but I wanted to be out helping people, and I knew that deterred many from looking my way.

"I don't know..."

"A beauty like yourself is sure to catch someone's eye."

"Oh, you are too kind. I'm just here to help and learn; nothing more."

"We'll see." She said with a twinkle in her eye. "Now, let me show you to your room and we'll get settled for tonight. Tomorrow, I'll have you fetch me some things from town that will help you familiarize yourself with Tallour. I'll send Tefyus with you for company and protection."

It was the perfect opportunity to tell her about the wolf.

"Tefyus actually saved me from a wolf on my journey here."

She turned to me, placing a hand upon her heart. "My dear child, why didn't you tell me sooner?"

"Oh, I didn't want to worry you when I first arrived." I quickly replied. "I'm fine, though."

She smiled, understanding. "I'm glad you are okay, but I'm going to talk to Leonard. He should have told me as well."

I pinched my lips this time. "Actually, he didn't see it."

Then I went on to explain in detail what had happened.

"A black wolf, you say," her expression worrisome. "Hmmm. This is unusual."

Then she looked at me. "Stay in town and don't wander off. I'd hate for it to happen again."

I nodded, letting her know I would do as she said.

Then she gave a soft smile, looking at the bird, who was now awake.

“I’m proud of you,” she told him, “you did your duty well.”

He fluttered his feathers, puffing out his chest, and it made me giggle at his actions.

Then grandmother turned back to me.

“He protects those he cares about, and I can tell you mean a great deal to him already.”

Then, her expression turned serious. “Trust him. He will never fail you Emma. Know this.”

Her words pierced my soul, and I knew they were true. I looked at my friend who was sitting on his perch, and I felt an overwhelming feeling of love towards the animal who not only saved me from the wolf, but provided friendship when I had none, and comfort when my father passed. He truly did care.

Then I left the kitchen and followed grandmother up to my room where I hoped I would be staying for a long time.

Chapter 9

I woke up the next morning, the sun shining through my window, and everything felt right in the world. I had so many answers already from the tingling in my fingers and it explained the reason why I was so drawn to be a healer. Everything was making sense. Tallour wasn't cursed; it was a blessing, and I couldn't wait to explore all it had to offer.

I got up to ready for the day. I already bathed last night, getting rid of all the grime from the long trip. Grandmother let me put lavender oil in my bath, and it calmed all my nerves.

I put on a practical dress and headed downstairs to see grandmother in the kitchen.

“Good morning.”

“Good morning, Emma. Did you sleep well?”

“Yes.” It was true. The bed felt like a dream, even though the room was smaller than I was used to, it fit all my stuff and I was happy with it.

“After breakfast, I'll show you my apothecary right here in the house, along with the greenhouse that I use to keep certain herbs, fruits, and veggies that I grow year round. Then I'll have you help me make a salve and come with me to the bakers to deliver it.”

“That sounds wonderful.”

I was grateful she was letting me jump right in and help her.

We ate quickly and soon she was showing me around the cottage. We entered the room that had multiple beds.

“Here's where I keep patients that need to be tended to overnight.” She pointed out as we walked past the beds to another door across the room. She opened it, and we entered the largest apothecary I have ever seen. The herbs in her kitchen were nothing compared to the vast expanse of vials, jars, and tools that were before me; along with bookshelves that held precious knowledge I couldn't wait to sit down and learn about. She sat down on a stool and started to give me instructions on herbs I would need to make the salve for a young boy who burned himself while trying to help his father bake bread one morning.

“Poor Jake, he tripped on his way to the oven and caught himself on the stove which led to a severe burn on his hands.”

“Is it healing, okay?”

“Yes, he’s almost out of his salve, and his mother came by yesterday asking for more.”

I finished creating the salve and put it in a clean jar to deliver.

I turned, holding the jar up for inspection, and she smiled. “It’s perfect. You have quite the skills already. Who knows, maybe I’ll learn something from you,” she winked and my chest filled with pride at her compliment.

Then she stood up but I noticed her limp was a little worse than yesterday.

“Why don’t I just deliver it while you go and rest.” I pointed towards her hip.

“Are you sure?”

“Of course. I often did solo visits like this for Healer Benton back in Gale. I can even make you some tea before I leave to help you with the pain.”

“It’s funny how one knows the knowledge to heal but barely uses it on themselves.” She told me with raised brows.

I understood what she meant. There have been times when I have been sick or afflicted with some ailment but barely used the same treatments on myself that I graciously gave to those in my care.

“That’s why I am here, to help you in any way that I can and to give you the treatment you deserve, that you have so willingly given to others.”

“You have the true heart of a healer, Emma, and I’m proud you are my granddaughter.” I flushed deeper and gave her a smile.

“Thank you.” I smiled, then went about making her tea. Once she was settled, I placed the salve in the basket, along with the list of items she needed. After getting directions to the baker’s shop, I grabbed my cloak, and headed out the door to be stopped by the sound of my winged friend.

Kaw!

I turned, and he flew from his perch to land on my shoulder to my great surprise. I gave him a sideways glance, wondering if he would stay there or fly away once I started walking, then he nuzzled my head with his beak.

“Ready?” I asked with a grin and he kawked as we headed out the door to get the errands done together.

Grandmother was right, I felt safer with him perched on my shoulder. It gave me the confidence to face the strangers of this town that I just arrived at.

The air was brisk, and I was surprised by the chill that still lingered with the summer season. I breathed in deeply and tugged the cloak around me, grateful for my mother's parting gift even though I knew I would stand out due to the dark red color.

I made my way down the road towards the center of town where people were busy buying goods for the day. I stayed close to the edge, trying not to draw attention to myself as I looked for the baker sign above the shops. When I spotted a picture of a loaf of bread carved out on the sign, I knew I was close.

To my left I heard a clinking sound and turned to see what was making it. In the distance, I saw a tall, broad man whose back was to me, his face hidden by the shadows of his shop. He lifted a hammer and brought it down on whatever he was working on. Sparks flew from the hot red metal he was maliciously forming into the item he wanted. He must be the town's blacksmith and I looked at my list to see if grandmother needed any items from there, and saw she needed a new metal bowl that was ready to be picked up. I would go there after delivering the salve.

Right as I turned to enter the baker's shop, Tefyus flew off my shoulder and swooped into the blacksmith's shop across the street and landed on a table near the man, who was still pounding away as if he wanted to watch him. The man paused for a moment, scratched under the bird's chin, then went back to work. I was curious about the relationship Tefyus had with this man, but grandmother said to trust him, so I didn't call him back. I also didn't want to draw attention to myself, so I turned back to the door and entered the bakery.

I'd be at the blacksmith's soon enough and my grandmother's patient came first.

"Good morning!" A short round man with a mustache smiled at me when I entered. "What can I get for you today?"

"I'm actually here to deliver the salve from Granny Tully." I picked the jar out of my basket and showed it to him.

"Oh, yes. You must be her granddaughter, Emma. She's been talking about you all week and is so excited to have you here. She's done wonders for my boy's burn, and I couldn't be more grateful."

“I’m so glad to hear that. I’ll be helping her for the next little while, so let me know if you need more salve or if there is anything else we can do.”

“I will.” Then he handed me some coins as payment, along with some bread. “Best bread you’ll ever eat, no one makes it like we do.”

Looking at the beautiful round loaf with designs cut into it; I believed him.

“I can’t wait to try it.” I held up the loaf to emphasize my words, before placing it in the basket. “Thank you.”

I said my goodbyes and headed out the door and across the street to the blacksmith’s to grab my grandmother’s bowl and Tefyus. I couldn’t hear any more clanking, and when I peeked inside the forge, the man was no longer there. I went around to the front of his shop and entered, the door making a ringing sound from the bell above me.

“I’ll be there in a moment.” A deep voice called from the back and I decided to look around while waiting.

The shop was filled with all kinds of pots, pans, utensils, bowls, and knives. They were all shining with high-quality craftsmanship that showed this blacksmith had a talent and skill that exceeded most.

Swords were hung up on the wall with elegant designs carved into the blade and handle. Needless to say, everything was beautiful. There was a small table in the corner that held small trinkets, broaches, bracelets, necklaces, and all sorts of jewelry. I walked over to take a look and one in particular stood out to me. A beautiful pendant that had a wolf’s face carved out in its center. It wasn’t like the black monster in the forest, but a beautiful and majestic animal.

“You like wolves, do you?” I was so startled by the deep voice that I dropped the pendant and hurriedly bent to pick it up, hoping he didn’t think me clumsy, or worse, disrespectful.

“I’m so sorry, I...” My words left me as I looked at the man behind the counter, holding out the pendant to him,

I lowered it along with my gaze. He was the most beautiful man I have ever seen. He was tall, corded with muscle, and probably only a few years older than me.

Needing to do something besides stare at him, I turned back to the table that held the jewelry and placed the pendant back where it came from.

I heard footsteps coming up behind me and turned around to see him only a few feet from me.

My heart jumped with an emotion I didn't quite understand.

The long sleeves of his dark green shirt were rolled up to his elbows, and he wore a leather apron with tools in the pockets that stuck out. He had black pants and dark brown boots on, but I couldn't help it as my gaze roamed over his handsome, chiseled face, which was clean-shaven. It was as if he was carved from perfection himself.

His hair was the same color as mine; dark auburn. It was short on the sides and long on top and combed in a style that made his look even more appealing. Out of everything, though, it was his eyes that seized my attention the most. They were such a beautiful light blue, they almost seemed surreal. I couldn't help but stare into them as they seemed almost wild and untamed.

"So, you don't like wolves then?" he chuckled at me, and I finally broke my connection, tilting my head down at his question, embarrassed I was gawking at him for so long.

"Huh? Wolves?" I blathered out like some simpleton. I wished I could have died right then and there with how much I looked and sounded like a fool in front of this handsome man.

Then he leaned towards me, and I got nervous, only to realize he was reaching for the pendant I had just put back on the table behind me. I should have stepped back, but I was frozen to the floor. He was so close and smelled so good, like a fresh spring in the woods.

I don't know what overcame me, but I breathed him in deeply, only to realize my actions made an embarrassing noise that sounded like I was sniffing him.

Which I realized...I WAS!

What was wrong with me?

My face was burning brighter than my cloak now.

It's not like I've never seen a man before. That's all my father's business was; young, tall, and masculine men who worked hard to bring in fish for his business, but none of them looked or smelled like this man before me. In fact, now that I thought about it, it was probably the smell that kept me at bay from them. One could only handle so much fish odor in one's life. He smelled nothing like that and I had to hold myself back from taking another deep breath of his intoxicating scent.

He straightened and held out the pendant I was previously looking at. I was grateful he seemed unaware of my embarrassing actions.

I took it from his hands, our fingers touching in the exchange. A tingle went from my fingers, up my arm, and straight to my chest, where something stirred within me. I looked up at his eyes again, wondering if he felt it too. He was gazing down at me with a broad smile on his face and I couldn't help but return it.

"I'm not sure," I whispered, finally answering his question, thinking back on the experience I had with the black wolf.

"Well, maybe I can change that for you," He winked with a devilish grin, and my heart fluttered.

Kaw! Kaw!

We both turned to the crow now perched on a high shelf in the shop, and I glared at the bird for intruding on our moment. He tilted his head and gave a soft coo as if to apologize, and I couldn't help but forgive him. It was probably for the best. Most men usually didn't seek me out, so nothing would ever come of this. The fact is, I was plain, but in this moment I wished with all my heart that I had the beauty of my sister.

"It seems Tefyus agrees." The man chuckled as he turned to the crow, surprised he was so familiar with the bird, and it only added to it when the crow swooped down and landed on his shoulder.

"Is he like that with everyone?" I asked, thinking that maybe I wasn't so special after all.

"No, but we are often together, and he's been a good friend since I came here."

"Oh, are you new to Tallour, too?" Trying to keep the eagerness from my voice. It would be nice to at least have a friend.

"Not new. I've been here about three years, but that's new compared to those who have lived here for generations. Granny Tully helped me when I first arrived."

I waited for him to tell me more, but when I realized he wasn't, I decided it was time to do what I came for.

"Speaking of Granny Tully, my grandmother wanted me to pick up a bowl from here. She said it was paid for already?"

He nodded, then made his way behind the counter and pulled out a medium sized bowl, its metal shined to perfection as he set it on the counter.

“This is the one.” He motioned towards it and I stepped towards the counter to pick it up and admire his artisanship.

“You do beautiful work.”

“Thank you. It’s a family trade I’ve worked long and hard to perfect.”

“Is your family here with you?” I looked around as if they would pop right through the door and say hello.

“Sadly, no.”

I couldn’t help but reach out and place a hand on his. The loneliness in his eyes pierced me, and I wanted to comfort this masculine, handsome man before me, since I knew how it felt to be so far from those you loved. I realized my boldness when he slowly removed his hand from mine, and I quickly drew my hand back as embarrassment made me flush.

What was wrong with me! Touching men I barely knew.

Maybe this town was cursed! Cursed with making people do things they normally wouldn’t.

“I’m sorry.” I told him, both for his loss and my forwardness.

Then I turned and left the blacksmith as fast as possible, heading straight to grandmother’s cottage, not caring if the crow didn’t follow. I knew he could take care of himself.

When I finally made it to grandmother’s kitchen, I realized I had forgotten to grab the bowl! I mentally kicked myself for getting distracted. Now I’d have to make another trip back and face the man I just embarrassed myself in front of.

A knock sounded on the kitchen door and I prayed it was someone who was ill and not the man I just ran away from, but when I opened the door, it seemed fate would not be on my side today as he stood just outside the doorway holding the bowl out for me to take.

“In your rush to leave, you seemed to have forgotten this.” He grinned with a twinkle in his eye, but I couldn’t find humor in it, only mortification.

“Thank you,” I told him softly as I grabbed the bowl from his hands, making sure not to touch his fingers again. Embarrassed that he had to bring it all the way to me because I kept making a dolt out of myself. I needed to pull myself together. This was not how healers acted.

“I also wanted to give you this, but you left before I could.” He dug inside the pocket of his leather apron and pulled out the wolf pendant.

“Oh, I couldn’t possibly-”

But my words were cut off when he reached forward and boldly grabbed my hand, pulling it towards him and placing the pendant in my palm.

“It’s a gift,” he said softly.

Another tingle shot up my arm, and my heart started pounding from his touch. He didn’t move his hand right away, so I just stared at the beautiful carved wolf since I didn’t want to break the connection just yet.

“Thank you. It’s beautiful,” I finally told him once I knew I could speak.

“I guess that is a ‘yes’ to my question then.” My eyes darted up to him to see him watching me intensely.

“Hmmm?” I blinked at him. He chuckled and released my hand, taking the warmth with him.

“Is that Benjamin?” My grandmother called from the other room.

“Yes, Granny Tully.” He responded before I could.

Benjamin. It was perfect.

I hoped she didn’t see our exchange.

Even if she did, it didn’t matter.

It meant nothing.

Why did my heart sink at that thought?

She made her way into the kitchen, and I noticed her limp was practically gone. I was grateful I learned remedies before I came so that I could be useful to her, not that she couldn’t make them herself, but she needed someone to take care of her for once.

“Why don’t you stay for tea?” Grandma asked him as she looked between us with a large smile and raised eyebrows.

She must have seen what had happened.

“I wish I could, but I just came to drop off your bowl.”

“Oh, well, thank you. It seems you have met my granddaughter.” She motioned towards me.

“Yes.” He smiled at me and held my gaze. “Well, I must be going, the forge cannot heat itself. Goodbye, Grandma Tully. Emma.” He said each of our names with a quick nod of his head and turned to leave.

“Wait!” I stepped forward, and he turned to me with raised brows. I hesitated before blurting out my question. “How do you know my name?”

“A little crow told me.” He winked, then turned and left. I watched him for a few seconds until Tefyul swooped through the door and landed on his perch in the kitchen as if summoned.

Kaw!

I looked towards the bird, whose stance was one of pride. He lifted his beak and puffed out his chest as if he was so proud of himself. Then I turned back to the door where the blacksmith was nowhere to be seen, then down at my hand where I grasped the pendant between my fingers, wondering if grandmother had told him my name before I came.

Yes, that’s it. The baker knew, so she must have told everyone else, too.

“Well, that was interesting.” Grandmother spoke, and I turned to see her looking at me with a wide smile.

“It was.” I said softly, then closed the door. The only thing cursed in this town was me, because I knew those beautiful blue eyes would haunt me for the rest of my days.

Chapter 10

The next morning, grandmother took me to her apothecary and showed me some old books with recipes for salves, and teas, along with a plant encyclopedia that described each plants uses; good and bad.

“It’s not only good to know how to heal with herbs, plants, and roots, but you also must know the more deadly plants and their purposes. Everything has a place in this world, from the smallest seed to the largest tree. Bark isn’t just good for kindling, but some can heal and relieve pain. Some leaves can bring back life; others can take it away. We have a choice every day to choose what we will do with this knowledge and gift we have been given.”

“Have those with this gift ever gone...bad?”

Grandmother sighed, “Not from our lineage, but yes, there have been those who have abused the gift to manipulate those around them to get what they desire; whether it be wealth, status, or power.”

“Does mother have this gift?” The question that has been burning in my mind finally left me.

“She does, but she chose not to nurture it.” Then she turned to look me straight in the eye and spoke with a serious tone. “With this gift comes responsibilities; not just to those around us, but to those who are like us. Others carry certain gifts that are different and many come to Tallour to find safety and healing. It is our job as healers to help all those in need no matter how different they may be.”

“What kind of gifts do others have? Are there any in this town now?” I was curious if the blacksmith was one of those who had a special gift. He mentioned that when he came to this town three years ago, grandmother had helped him. I wondered how?

“It is not my place to tell, but the more your gift grows, the more you will be able to know and tell what others’ gifts are.”

“How? Can you teach me now?”

She smiled at me and shook her head. “It’s not something you can teach, but something you learn individually. You’ll feel it in your heart, and you’ll just know.” She lightly touched above my heart and then my forehead.

“I won’t let you down, grandmother.”

“I know you won’t.”

She grabbed some books from her shelves and handed them to me to read while giving me some assignments to make some salves that were good for healing cuts and bruises.

“It is always good to have on hand. I also will teach you some new medical procedures. Not everything can be mended with salves and teas. A good healer knows all techniques for any ailment.”

“Healer Benton taught me how to properly clean and wrap a wound.”

“Good. I will also teach you how to close large wounds, reset bones, and deliver babies. It is also good to know what herbs they can and cannot take while expecting.”

I was beyond thrilled that she was truly going to make me into a proper healer and that I would be able to help anyone who came to me.

The rest of the day passed quickly as I lounged on the window seat reading and then creating the salves she wanted. Once I finished, I went out to find her in her garden picking some lavender. The sun was almost set, and darkness would soon take over the day.

“Let me help,” I called her and started to make my way down the path. Suddenly, a howl filled the air, and I froze. Grandmother didn’t seem phased by the wolf’s call, but maybe she was too busy picking the flowers she didn’t notice.

“Grandmother. Maybe we should go inside.” She stood up and turned to me with a confused look, then two howls pierced the air and her eyes went wide.

“You’re right, deary. Quickly now. Get inside.”

She grabbed the bunch of lavender in her arms and shuffled her way towards me. I turned and ran to the door, keeping it open until she was inside. My heart pounded with anxiety as another howl filled the air.

Once she was in, she quickly motioned for me to lock it, but I didn’t need to be told, I was halfway done by the time she said something.

Once finished I leaned against its frame, but Grandmother didn’t stop though, she went by the table and dropped the lavender, then went straight to the apothecary.

I wondered what was going on.

“Emma, I need you to prepare some bandages, I am going to...”

She didn't finish her sentence before a loud knock sounded on the front door, and I turned to it, wondering if that was the reason she became so frantic.

"Please answer the door. I'll be out in a moment."

I hesitated at first since I was afraid a large black wolf was on the other side waiting to finish its job.

"Don't be afraid, dear. It's just Benjamin."

The blacksmith? I'd take the wolf.

I was still embarrassed about how I acted in front of him yesterday, but my feet carried me to the door, and I composed myself before opening it. He looked shaken and stepped inside before I even got a word out and I knew something was wrong.

"Sorry, Emma, is Granny here? There has been an incident. William, the carpenter's boy has gone missing, and I need to speak with her."

"I'm right here, Benjamin." She stepped into the kitchen with a basket in her arms and handed it to me. I stepped forward to take it from her.

"This has all the supplies needed once we find the boy," she told me. "I need you to stay here and get one of the beds ready. Put a pot of boiling water on the stove, along with strips of fresh linens."

Then she stepped towards the blacksmith, who opened the door for her, but she stopped in the doorway and turned back to me.

"Stay safe. We'll be back soon." Then she turned to look at Tefyus, "come."

He flew from his perch and landed on her shoulder, eager to serve her as she made her way into the night.

Before Benjamin followed her, he turned to me, one hand still on the nob. His gaze penetrated mine as his jaw clenched, as if he was trying to think of something to say, but didn't know the words.

I stepped forward, "be safe."

His shoulders slumped, and a small smile graced his face, "you, too."

Another howl happened, and we both turned to look outside.

"Don't open this door for anyone," he ordered, then quickly left.

I quickly locked the door behind them, then rushed around to make sure all the doors were secure. I lit extra candles before going about the

tasks that grandma assigned me. Once finished, I sat at the kitchen table waiting for their return and praying they would find the boy soon and that he would be alright.

An hour passed and I was becoming more anxious with each minute until a pounding on the kitchen door made me leap from my seat.

“Emma! It’s Ben. I have the boy. Please, let me in.”

I rushed to the door and flung it open to see a young boy in his arms, probably about six or seven years old. He had blood on his arm that soaked through his shirt. I looked to see if grandmother was right behind him, but when it was only him and the boy, I became worried.

“Where’s my grandmother?” I asked while leading them to the room with the beds, telling him to lay the boy down.

“She should be here soon. She told me to run ahead and get him taken care of. Tefyus is with her, so no harm will come to her.”

I thought of how the bird had saved me and knew he was right.

“What happened,” I asked as I examined the boy on the bed.

“Found him in a ditch in the woods, just outside of town. It seems as if he scraped himself, but nothing seems broken.”

It was as if I was back with Healer Benton, and my body and mind moved with precision since it knew what to do. After getting the shirt off the boy and revealing the deep cut, it looked more like a bite mark with a few scratches on his arm. I immediately thought of the wolf’s howls that we heard only an hour ago and how grandmother reacted.

It was as if she knew.

“This is a bite mark,” I pointed out to Benjamin, who looked closer only to go pale as a ghost.

“Are you alright?” I asked, concerned. He cleared his throat, “yes.”

Maybe the sight of blood makes him queasy and I felt bad for pointing the bite out, but he carried the lad all the way here and seemed fine. I’d think about it later; I had work to do.

“Go lay down on the bed.” I ordered him and pointed to the bed right next to the boys. Him fainting wouldn’t help my situation since I needed to tend to the boy. He got up without any protest and laid down.

I went to the stove to grab the hot water along with some fresh clean cool water and began cleaning the wound. I took a jar of salve and placed a generous amount on the wound. It would not only help with the

pain, but promote healing along with protecting it from infection. I was grateful the cuts weren't deep and didn't need stitches. I knew what to do, but Healer Benton never actually let me perform the procedure.

I decided that is what I would ask granny to teach me next.

After carefully wrapping the wound and tying it off I got up to make him some tea for when he woke up to help him sleep tonight and promote healing.

"You're remarkable, Emma." I turned to the sound of the deep voice and realized I almost forgot he was there. Ben was still laying down looking at me with a small smile and a tender look that made my whole body flush.

"I can tell you truly care about helping people and are going to be a great healer one day, if you aren't already."

"Thank you. I'm just doing what I love." I responded softly and turned back around to continue making the tea, my heart full from his compliment. Then the door swung open and I turned around to see who it was. Benjamin hopped up from the bed as if he was ready to fight whoever came through the door. Luckily it was only grandmother followed by a man and a woman, who had tears streaming down her face.

"Oh, where is he? Where is my boy?" The woman cried out. Her black hair and shawl were covered in leaves as she made her way over to the bed, where her child lay. She cried even louder when she saw his arm covered in bandages.

"Oh, my dear, dear, sweet boy. What happened to you?"

I stepped up to her and put a hand on her shoulder to comfort her. The father came around and sat on the bed that the blacksmith was previously laying on and took off his hat then ran both hands through his hair while letting out a sigh.

"He'll be alright," I assured them. "I think he was bitten by an animal, but it wasn't deep enough to need stitches. I applied an ointment that will not only promote healing but keep infection out."

"Oh, how can I ever repay you?" The mother turned to me with glistening eyes.

I turned to Benjamin, who was just outside the infirmary door, "Don't thank me. Benjamin is the one who found him."

"But it is Miss Emma's hands that have truly helped him. He is well taken care of, I can assure you."

“Oh, bless you two. We sent him out to check the rabbit traps for tonight’s dinner and when he didn’t return...” Her shoulders shook as she cried into her hands, and I gave her another hug to try and comfort her.

“He is safe now and taken care of.”

She nodded and stood up. Her husband picked up the boy and I gave them instructions on cleaning the wound and applying salve twice a day to help keep out infection.

“Just return here if you have any concerns, worries, or if the wound doesn’t heal.”

Then we walked them to the door and said our goodbyes. Once they were out of sight, I turned to find the blacksmith right behind me, and I became very aware of just how close we were.

“I must get going, too.” He softly told me as he looked over my face, then down at my hands.

He picked them up in his and my heart started pounding in my chest, my fingers burning from our connection. His hands were so large and rough compared to mine. His work in the forge made them so, but I didn’t mind, in fact, I didn’t want him to let go, which was so strange since I barely knew this man.

“Your hands did wonders today for that boy, Emma. I know that if I ever need help, I will be well taken care of by you.” I wanted to deny it and tell him that I was just a beginner and that my grandmother was the one who was more qualified, but the words stuck in my throat as I looked up at him and saw the truth of his words blazing from his eyes. He leaned forward, his gaze dropped to my lips and then back to mine, making my breath catch in my throat. Then he closed his eyes and turned his face away from me, and huffed out a large breath.

Rejection settled in my heart and I dropped back on my heels, now realizing I was anticipating his next action. I pulled my hands out of his and started to make my way around him. A gentle hand touched my arm and I stopped, took a deep breath, and turned to face him. His eyes were now cold and even hostile, so different from the warmth of just a few seconds ago. I instinctively pulled back at his demeanor, wondering what made him change so quickly and I could only guess that it was because of me since no one else was in the room.

“I’m dangerous, Emma. You shouldn’t be around me. It’s better this way.”

“I understand.”

I knew I was no beauty. That belonged to my older sister. I was average and often overlooked by men. Why would a man, who could have any woman he wanted, settle for a girl like me? I turned to leave, but his hand was still gently wrapped around my arm, and I didn't have the courage to pull it away.

“You don't understand.” He told me desperately and hated myself for looking back at him when I should have just left, his eyes now full of pain. I almost wanted to reach out to him, but his rejection was clear and I wouldn't beg to be wanted. I was above such things even though it still hurt.

“It's okay, you don't need to explain yourself.”

“I wish I could.” Then he rubbed his hands through his hair and gave a frustrated growl.

My hand reached out as I placed it on his forearm to get his attention, and gave him the best smile I could muster and offered something that was the next best thing, even though I knew I would always want to be more.

“Friends?” Then I took my hand off his arm and held it out for him to shake, but he surprised me when he stepped closer to me and gently grabbed my chin, tilting it up to meet his gaze that was now full of longing. My breath caught as he rubbed his thumb along my jaw, my whole body on fire from his touch. We stayed like that for a moment, trapped in each other's eyes. Confusion swirled in my mind from his ever-changing emotions.

Then he took a deep breath and smiled. “Friends...for now.”

What did he mean by that?

I didn't get the chance to ask because he quickly turned and disappeared into the night.

I closed the door and latched the lock in place, wondering what had just happened. I turned and to my great relief, I found grandmother nowhere in sight, grateful an audience wasn't here to witness the scene that just happened.

I found her in the apothecary, putting items away.

“Is Benjamin gone?” she asked me with her back turned.

“Yes.” I stepped forward to see if she needed any help, only to find she was just about finished putting the extra linens away.

“I’m so glad he found the boy. That would have been tragic if he had stayed missing until morning, especially with those wolves outside.” She paused, then turned to me. “He’s a good man. I can always rely on him.”

But she still didn’t answer my question.

“How did you know, grandmother? After the wolves howled, you seemed to just know. Has it happened before?”

“Not everything is as it seems, and it’s our job as healers to always be prepared.” She smiled and put a hand on my shoulder. She was right, but it still didn’t answer my question about how she knew it was Benjamin at the door.

“It’s been a long night. Why don’t you go get ready for bed, and we’ll talk more about it later.”

I hugged her, then wished her goodnight, making my way up to my room, thinking about the blacksmith.

Friends...for now.

What did he mean by that? Did he want more? Less? As I lay in bed my mind busy with the day’s events and the riddle that was now before me, I finally fell asleep, but right before I did, I heard another howl. This time, it was deep, sad, and full of longing. I wanted to help the poor creature, and I soon realized that its song was the one my own heart sang. I fell asleep to the mournful cries as my own tears fell down my cheeks at what I would never have.

Chapter 11

“You’re still thinking too hard. Magic is more of an emotion, a feeling, not a thought process.”

Grandmother told me as my hands were shoved into the dirt next to the plants. We’ve been at it an hour and I still couldn’t feel that sensation that I did previously when I was back in Gale.

I let out a frustrated sigh and pulled my hands back into my lap. “Maybe I don’t have a gift, and it was just a figment of my imagination.”

“Don’t sell yourself short, deary, some of the greatest healers in our line have taken years to perfect their magic.”

Kaw!

I turned towards the crow, who had been watching us all morning and into the afternoon. He swooped down and rubbed my hand with his head. I scratched under his chin in return, grateful for his comfort and confidence.

“See, even Tefyus agrees!” Grandmother exclaimed with an encouraging smile.

Kaw! Kaw!

I smiled at the crow’s support, but doubt soon filled me and another sigh left my lips. I didn’t want to wait years. We have been at it three weeks and I have made no progress in helping the newly planted seeds grow. They were still the same small buds that had popped up only last week. I thought about my time in Gale and how just wishing I had more plants for my sister’s wedding made my whole garden flourish, but it seemed that blessing wouldn’t happen anytime soon. While I was making progress in other things such as stitching deep cuts and setting bones, since one of the boys in town fell from a tree and got a cut on his head and broke his arm; the garden still stayed the same.

“Maybe we can take a break and come back to it later, I want to show you something.” She smiled at me and made her way towards the house.

I stood up to follow her, my excitement overruling any thoughts of failure I had in the garden, wondering what she would show me.

She made her way past the kitchen and into her personal room, which I have never been in until now. It was simple, just like mine, with a bed in the corner, but it was bright with flowers placed around her room in pots that only alluded to her talent since they were bright and full bloom with no blemishes on any of its petals. She made her way over to a dresser that had a large mirror hanging above it and pulled out the top drawer, pushing things around as if searching for something. My curiosity grew and I made my way over to her. She pulled out something small and turned to show me what was in her palm. My eyes went wide and a small gasp left my mouth when I saw the most beautiful ring I've ever seen was in her hand. It was a ruby that was carved in the shape of a rose with two emeralds shaped like leaves below it. The metal band that held the precious jewel was also shaped like leaves, only adding to its intricate design.

"This ring has been in our family for years and is given to the next generation when they turn eighteen and come into their powers."

She placed it in my palm and pushed my fingers over. "I didn't give it to you right away because I wasn't sure how you would react when I told you about the healer's magic. Your mother..." I looked up at her and saw her eyes glistening with tears, waiting for her to finish.

"Now, it is yours if you want it. Don't doubt your heritage. It will take time, but I know you will do great things to help those around you."

She took her hands off of mine and I opened my fingers to look down at the ring she gave me, then grasped it firmly and wrapped my arms around her in a fierce hug to which she returned.

"Thank you, grandmother. I will do my best to learn from you and live up to our family name."

"I know you will." Then she pulled back and grabbed my shoulders and gave me a smile. "Now, let us get ready to visit those in town, what do you say?"

"You mean I get to go with you?" I asked excitedly. She usually left by herself and I was in charge of staying here in case anyone came by and needed help.

"Who will watch the cottage?" I looked around her room, worried.

"Tefyus will let us know if something is amiss."

KAW! The bird screeched from downstairs and I laughed aloud.

“Okay, I’ll grab the basket.” I went to my room first and opened the jewelry box I brought with me from home, only to see a beautiful metal pendant with a wolf carved into it staring up at me. I carefully placed the ring inside and took the pendant out to look at it. After that night three weeks ago when the blacksmith told me he just wanted to be friends, I took the pendant off my neck that I was secretly wearing under my dress and placed it in my jewelry box to get him out of my mind. I also avoided any interactions with him, and when grandmother sent me to the market for food or other things we needed, I made sure to run past his forge and prayed he didn’t spot me or call me out. Not that he would, I was nothing special to him since I often saw him talking to the other young woman of this town who tended to linger around his shop.

One in particular was a girl named Rachel Wendell, who was the beauty of this town and the Overseer’s daughter. She had long blonde hair and eyes that sparkled. When she laughed at anything the blacksmith said, it was as if bells were chiming. I almost hated her for her perfection but her kindness only made me realize how my feelings were wrought by jealousy, when she also treated me with the same dignity as everyone else. She even invited me over for tea once, but I had to decline when grandmother needed help when Madam White went into labor, only to realize it was braxton hicks and not true labor contractions.

I started to put the pendant back but at the last second I pulled it over my neck and shoved it down my shift to be hidden from others. Then I quickly headed downstairs to prepare all we needed for our visits.

Once I entered the apothecary, I grabbed salves and certain herbs for teas off the shelves that we would be giving those in town with certain ailments. I often helped grandmother prepare the basket before she left, so I knew what she needed. I was learning so much. Her knowledge was beyond what Healer Benton or any other healer I’ve known, and I was soaking it up to its fullest.

I made my way out and saw her standing by the door with Tefyus on her shoulder, a walking stick in one hand and a basket in the other.

I looked at her walking stick. She only used it when her hip was bothering her. “Is your hip okay? Should I make you some tea before we leave?” I offered her, pointing to the kettle by the stove.

“No, my dear. There’s only so much tea can do when you get to be my age. I’ll put some salve on it when we get back. Come, let us go, we

only have so much daylight.”

I hesitated not wanting her to be in pain but she gave me a soft smile, opened the door, and headed out, only giving me the option to follow. She was right, it was already afternoon, and we had to make our rounds before dark. There were wolves in these woods and I didn’t want to be caught as prey to them like I was on my journey here. Luckily, there were no more incidents that happened since William, the carpenter’s son, was bitten.

I often heard them at night though, but it usually sounded like a lone wolf whose cry pierced my soul. We never actually found out if it was a wolf who bit him, but it only made sense. Once he became conscious, he told his father what happened. While he was checking the traps one of the rabbits was still alive and struggling. He went to set it free, but he heard a growl behind him and ran, only to be chased by some dark animal that bit his arm and threw him down and into a ditch where he lost consciousness. Recalling his story sent shivers of fear down my spine. I was grateful Benjamin found the boy just in time.

Once we were in town, we headed towards the carpenter’s to check on the boy. We found him sitting outside on the porch playing with a toy. When he saw us he leaped down the stairs to greet us.

“Emma! Granny Tully! Look, my arm is doing so much better.” He showed us his wrapped arm and moved it around, then flinched a little. “Well, it’s still a little bit sore, but Ben gave me this wolf since I was so brave.”

He held up the small metal wolf for us to see and it reminded me of the necklace that was hidden under my dress. I pressed my palm to my chest to touch the pendant the blacksmith gave me and my heart warmed at the kind gesture he did for the young boy.

“You were so brave, and we’ve come to give you some more salve to put on the wound.”

The door opened, and the boy’s mother came out.

“Good to see you Granny Tully and Emma!” she nodded to us.

“Hello, Marsha,” Grandmother said as she pulled out a jar from her basket and handed it to the boy’s mother. “Here’s some more salve for William’s wound, just put it on like normal.”

“I can’t thank you enough for all you have done to help my boy.”

“We are glad to help.” We said our goodbyes with William waving to us from the porch. I turned to my grandmother to see where we would be heading next to see her pulling a jar of salve out of her basket and handing it to me. My brows pulled together in confusion.

“I need you to take this to Benjamin while I attend to Madam White. She’s due any day now, and I’d thought we could split up our duties.”

“Benjamin?” Surely she wasn’t talking about the handsome blacksmith I’d been avoiding for weeks now, and prayed there was someone else by the same name in this town.

“Yes, Blacksmith Gray.” She confirmed my fears.

I held back a groan and thought of an excuse instead.

“If he’s sick, maybe you should be the one attending to him.”

Grandmother chuckled. “I can see an excuse a mile away, deary. I’m a healer after all.” Then she placed an arm on my shoulder and gave me a stern look, “and so are *you*.”

I almost rolled my eyes, but instead, I just looked down at my hands and huffed. I still had much to learn.

“He’s not sick, just needs some ointment for his hands. They’ve been cracking with the type of work he does and he asked me for some the last time I was in town. In fact, I’m sure he’ll be glad it’s you delivering it and not some old woman.” She smiled with a twinkle in her eye.

If she only knew.

“I’m far from the type of girl to catch his eye, Grandmother.”

Thinking of Rachel and the other young women in our town who were constantly pining for his attention, to which he gave, to my greatest annoyance.

Then she whispered with compassion, “Not only are you blind to your talents, but the beauty you are as well.”

Then she patted my hand and pushed me along. “Come to Madam Whites when you are done. She should deliver any day now, and I need to see if the baby’s head is down.”

I nodded and headed to the place I’ve been avoiding like the plague, which was ironic since I was a healer and was usually drawn to those places.

I didn’t hear any pounding of metal coming from the forge, so I went to his shop first to get my task over with. When I entered, the bell

sounded overhead and I looked around for the man who created all the beautiful work that now surrounded me. The blacksmith was nowhere to be found so I decided to explore his shop while waiting. Everything was as stunning, just as I remember from the first time I entered this place. I bent over to look at the intricate work on a small knife on the counter, when I heard voices.

“This town will never accept you.” A gruff voice said from an open door that led into the forge. I froze and stood up looking at the open door, wondering if I should leave.

“Leave me alone, Phil. I’m not like you anymore. I’ve changed.”

Then they made their way through the shop door, not noticing me standing there. The stranger looked just like Benjamin, except older and with hair as black as night. I turned to leave, deciding I would come back later, not wanting to intrude on their conversation.

“Changed! Ha! You...” The man paused, and they both looked up to see me standing there. Fear shot through me as the man’s yellow eyes pierced my soul since they reminded me of the large black wolf I encountered on my journey to this town. Grateful it was the only encounter that has happened since then.

“Emma!”

I shook my thoughts and turned to Benjamin, who was making his way towards me. I scrambled to reach for his salve in my basket and held it out towards him, and noticed a broad smile on his face just for me.

“Here is the salve Granny Tully sent me to give you.”

“Thank you,” his soft voice washed over me, making butterflies soar in my stomach.

I shouldn’t have come. He was dangerous for my heart, which only picked up in speed as his hands brushed mine when he took the jar from me

“If it was made by your hands, I know it will work wonders.”

I couldn’t help the flush that came to my cheeks, and I tried to brush it off.

“Just doing my job. I’m here to help everyone.”

“Everyone? I thought I was special.” He joked, placing a hand over his heart as if offended.

“Oh, I mean...everyone is...special. I didn’t mean to imply that you...” His chuckle stopped my mumbling, and I wished I could have melted into the floor and away from this place. I’d have to tell grandmother

I couldn't make any more deliveries to this man for my own well-being. The town would think I was incompetent with the way I acted around him since I could barely get a sentence out.

"It seems I've been humbled." He winked with a smirk, and my face heated.

A cough interrupted us, bringing me back to reality when a dark shadow towered over me. I turned to see the stranger step up beside me. He reached towards me, but I was too shocked by his abruptness to step back as he picked up the pendant that hung from my neck. I didn't realize it fell out while I was looking at the knife just a few moments ago.

He flipped it over in his fingers and slowly looked from me to Benjamin, his mouth pinched with frustration. Then he dropped it and I quickly grabbed the pendant, clutching it to my chest. Benjamin stepped in front of me, and I was grateful for his protection from this man, who gave off all the energy that screamed *danger*.

"I think it's time for you to leave...brother." He told the man in a firm voice. It made sense with how similar they looked, but I could tell their relationship was strained by the few words I've heard so far and I wondered the reason why.

He didn't move but stared at Benjamin with raised brows, "I'd be careful if I were you." he told him in a threatening voice. "someone..." he paused, leaning his body to look at me from behind his brother, "could get hurt."

"Leave now, and don't come back," Benjamin hissed to the man.

"We'll see." He turned and left the shop and I wondered if the threat was actually aimed towards me or if he was using me as a means to scare his brother.

I was grateful Benjamin didn't turn around right away since it gave me a moment to compose myself from the unusual exchange that had just happened.

Ben's shoulders raised as he took in a deep breath, then he turned to face me with one hand on his hip and the other pinching his nose. I reached out towards him and placed a hand on his arm.

"Is everything alright?"

"Yes." He huffed out, then ran a hand down his face, stopping to grip his chin while looking towards the door where his brother left. "I'm sorry about him. But don't worry. His bark is worse than his bite."

It didn't seem that way, but I didn't say anything.

Deciding he needed some space I turned to leave and go find my grandmother to tell her what had happened.

"Wait, Emma." I turned back to him and he stepped towards me and reached for the pendant around my neck, a grin replacing his worried expression as he looked at the gift he gave me and up to my eyes as he slowly dropped the necklace.

"Yes?" I asked with no emotion, and his brows pinched together at my indifference, then they softened with worry.

"Why have you been avoiding me?"

"I haven't been avoiding..." His raised eyebrows stopped me from finishing the lie.

"I've been busy." I told him bluntly while turning to leave before I got caught in any more of my lies. Not that I had many, only ones that involved staying as far away from the blacksmith as possible, especially if there were family disputes. I didn't want to get caught in the middle of something when I had so much to worry about already.

"Too busy? Even for a friend?" I paused in the doorway at his words and turned back to face him as he waited for my response.

"I thought you were too dangerous to be my friend? Therefore, I decided to heed your words and stay away." He nodded as if my words rang true, but stepped towards me anyway.

"I did say that, didn't I?" His mouth went into a straight line, and I could almost sense regret coming from him.

"I know I..." then he took a deep breath and put a smile on his face. "I was wondering if you would want to go with me to the Harvest Festival this Friday? As a friend, that is."

With each word, he stepped closer and closer until I had to tilt my head all the way back to look up into his eyes as he invaded my space with a grin. My heart betrayed me, as it pounded in my chest with his presence. I knew about the festival since grandmother mentioned I should go, but I told her I would rather stay home with her, but the real reason was now asking me and I decided that it was better to keep my heart tucked away then let this man play with it.

His words rang in my mind; *a friend. That is.*

I would never be anything more to this man than that, so why was he going out of his way to ask me? Did one of the other girls reject him

when he asked, and was I only a backup to his failed attempts?’

“Why don’t you ask the girls I see around your shop constantly? Surely you aren’t *too* dangerous for them? Maybe they could be *more* than just a *friend*.”

I raised my eyebrows and folded my arms in defiance as I threw his words back in his face, which I knew stemmed from jealousy, but I didn’t care. I also wished I would have kept my arms down since I was now touching his chest. To my surprise, he didn’t step back. In fact, he tilted towards me, then he whispered so close to my face I could feel his breath on my cheek.

“Watching my shop, are you?” He smirked, “If I didn’t know any better, I’d think you were jealous. Is that why you have been avoiding me?”

“Ha! No. It’s just hard to avoid the crowd I have to walk through every time I have a delivery to make. I’m busy with more important things than to be part of your group of admirers.”

It was my turn to pinch my lips and challenge him to deny my accusation, but the action made him glance down at my pursed lips, but I wasn’t having it.

“Plus, if you wanted to ask me, why didn’t you do it sooner?”

“I would have, *if* you would have responded when I called your name every time you passed my shop.”

It was true. Every time he called out to me, I ignored him and pretended I didn’t hear. Eventually, he stopped after a few times. I tried to think of a response to his claim, but all I could think about was how close we were now that if I pushed up on my toes, our lips would touch.

“I don’t want to take them, Emma. I want to take you.” He whispered, and a shiver went down my spine, and my countenance softened

“Benjamin, I...”

“It’s Ben.” He corrected softly, with a charming smile.

“Ben.” My heart melted at the familiarity, but my mind could only compare myself to the pretty ladies he was constantly around, and I knew better than to get caught up with this man who would soon realize I wasn’t worth his time.

I broke the connection since I didn’t have the courage to say my next words while looking into his beautiful eyes. “I’m sorry, I can’t.”

“Why not?” He hooked a finger under my chin and tilted my head back up to search my eyes, and was surprised when they seemed sad.

Why did he care? He had a whole slew of women, who constantly vied for his attention.

“Please tell me,” he pleaded after a moment of silence, and it broke my heart.

“I just...can’t.”

Then I fled without looking back, and instead of searching for grandmother, I ran back home to our cottage and locked myself in my room. Hoping I did the right thing.

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Chapter 12

“Emma, are you alright?”

My eyes fluttered open at my grandmother’s words that came through my bedroom door, and I realized I had fallen asleep on my bed.

“Yes.” My voice came out hoarse, and I cleared it before responding again. “Yes, I just fell asleep.”

I got up and opened the door to see a worried look on her face.

“Did Benjamin get his salve?”

“He did.”

“Anything else you want to talk about, deary?”

“No.” A look of concern overcame her features, and I wondered if she had talked to Ben. I wouldn’t dare ask, so I rushed to say my next words before she dug any deeper on my miserable afternoon. “I’ll go make us some tea and start on dinner. How does that sound?”

“If that’s what you wish to do. I’ll come help in a second. I need to grab a few ointments for Madam White. She’s already contracting, and I may have to stay at her house the next few days until the baby comes.”

“May I help you deliver?” I asked anxiously.

“Of course, but I’ll send Tefyus to you when the time comes, in case someone stops by while I’m gone.”

“That sounds wonderful.” I squealed with enthusiasm.

With that great news, my afternoon turned around. I couldn’t wait to help her deliver a baby, one of the most sacred and precious works I felt a healer could do. It would also keep me busy, so I wouldn’t have to attend the Harvest festival in the next few days. This was working out perfectly and I went downstairs to start a low fire in the hearth to make some vegetable soup for dinner, along with some leftover rolls from the bakery.

Afterwards, I helped grandmother prepare a basket she would take with her tonight, and we headed out the door.

“You don’t have to walk with me to town, Emma. I may be old, but I still got some life left in these bones.”

“Oh, I know that. I just want to make sure you get there safely and it will let me know where she lives. So, when Tefyus comes to get me, I don’t get lost.”

She nodded and said, “Right you are, Emma.”

Once we made it to a large Manor and I hugged grandmother goodbye, the bird hopped on my shoulder and we turned to make our way back to the cottage on the other side of town.

“Be careful, Emma.” She called back to me with pinched brows.

“I will!” I called back, then started walking briskly since the sun was going down, and I didn’t bring a lantern with me to see in the dark. Once we walked past the main shops and were finally on the dirt road that led to our cottage, a wolf’s howl pierced the air. Fear shot through me and I turned to the forest that surrounded Tallour, then looked back at the security of the town we just left.

Tefyus jumped off my shoulder, and I ran towards our cottage, hoping the bird was following me. That’s when I noticed a large dark animal was running in the woods next to me, its yellow eyes on my figure as it followed me home. I looked up ahead to see how close I was to having the protection of the cottage doors, then back to the woods. I screamed when the large animal jumped out of trees and bounded towards me, realizing it was the same monstrous black wolf from my journey here. I forced my body and mind to keep on running and not freeze like it did the previous time, knowing I might not get a second chance to live if it caught up to me. Then, a ferocious growl came right up behind me, and I knew I was too late.

I tucked myself into a ball, ready to face my doom, hoping the animal would spare my life as I cried out my last prayer.

But nothing happened

A different growl filled the air, and I turned to see another large wolf jump in front of me, placing itself between me and my offender. He crouched low with its teeth bared, ferocious snarls emanating the air between me and my adversary. His coat shined red from the setting sun that glowed around him. His fur standing on edge gave him a lethal look. He pounced at the black wolf’s neck, grabbing and thrashing him around, which brought me to my senses that I was now surrounded by two dangerous creatures, no matter if one of them just saved me.

I took my chance while they were distracted with their fight to bolt towards my cottage. I flung the gate open, slammed it shut, and did the same for the cottage door. After locking it, I placed a chair under the lock to secure it even more, then went around the house shutting all the windows and making sure the house was secure. Once I got to my bedroom on the

second floor and started shutting the window, I paused, realizing Tefyus was not with me and still out there among the wolves. Looking out the window I figured it was too high for the wolves to jump, so I left it slightly ajar, hoping it was enough room for the bird to squeeze through. I paced my room waiting for the bird, and when night soon took over, I decided he wasn't coming and went to shut my window to prepare for bed when all the sudden he swooped in and started flying around my head screeching at the top of its lungs.

Kaw! Kaw! Kaw!

"What is Tefyus? What's wrong?" I reached out to try and grab the bird to calm him down, but he slipped through my fingers and went towards the door, flapping in place while banging on the wood with its beak. I realized he was trying to tell me something."

"Is it grandmother?"

Kaw!

What did that mean!

"One kaw, yes. Two kaws, no." I told him.

Kaw! Kaw!

Relief filled me.

I opened the door, and he flew downstairs. I followed him to the kitchen where he pecked on the door that led to the garden.

"I can't go outside. There are wolves." I tried to reason with the bird, getting frustrated.

Kaw! Kaw!

"No. It's too dangerous! And if grandmother is safe, there's no need to leave until the sun comes up."

Facing wolves in the daylight was already dangerous enough.

He flew back to me and grabbed my sleeve, pulling me to the door. He was stronger than I thought, and I swatted at him.

"No! Stop it. What's wrong with you?"

KAW!

Then the words of my grandmother came to my mind. *Trust him. He will never fail you, Emma; know this.*

"Fine! But it is your fault if I die!" I scolded the bird and turned to grab a lantern so I could see what waited for me behind the safety of the wooden doors.

After moving the chair and unlatching the lock, I slowly opened the door. Tefyus flew straight into the night and landed next to a large shadow in the garden. I held my lantern up high to see what it was and saw the large form of the red wolf who had saved me earlier.

I hesitated, but the crow chirped at me and hopped towards me then back to the dangerous animal as if telling me to come. I looked around wondering if the black wolf was nearby before I stepped closer to get a better look. He was laying on the ground with blood matted on his neck and front legs. I could see large wounds that needed to be attended to quickly before they got infected. Looking around at the absurdity of the situation, I looked at the crow.

“If this turns out badly, I’m blaming you!” I told the bird for the second time, giving him a pointed look with pinched lips.

Kaw. He chirped softly, as understanding.

I crept closer, setting the lantern next to the huge beast and prodded him to see if he was conscious. When he didn’t budge, I shoved him harder and jumped back quickly, only to have no response, and I knew he was unconscious. I prayed he would stay that way for what I was about to do next, hoping I wouldn’t regret it. I lifted the front of his large body off the ground and made my way under him as I placed his paws over my shoulders with his head dangling to the side and his body dragging behind me.

I huffed out ragged breaths with each step I made towards the cottage. I tilted my head up to see how much farther and wished he would have dropped unconscious at the door, which made me grumble at the bird once more for the situation I found myself in. I slowly dragged the huge animal into the house, using all my strength to not topple over onto the dirt pathway. When we finally made it up the stairs, into the house, through the medical room door and next to one of the empty beds we use for patients, I finally dropped to my knees and scooted out from under his large body taking several large breaths. After a moments rest, I grabbed a clean sheet and tucked it under the wolf the best I could. Then I ran to the door and locked it again only to hesitate with my hand on the latch since I realized I was locking myself in *with* a predator that could take my life with one swipe, but I decided I feared the black monster more than the one who saved me and put the clock back in place.

I would know in the morning if I made the right decision.

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Chapter 13

Making my way back to the infirmary, I gathered supplies to tend to the wolf; bandages, salves, ointments and prayed the wolf would stay unconscious while I tried to help him. I was also grateful grandmother had a pump directly in her kitchen and apothecary, which made it easier for me since I didn't want to go outside again to get water to clean its wounds.

After gathering all the supplies, I knelt in front of the beast to take a better look at its injuries. Tefyus didn't make a sound as I placed clean cloths into the bucket, wrung it out, and started washing away the blood from its fur. After a thorough examination, I was relieved the marks weren't deep enough to need stitches, but there were so many, which was why there was blood everywhere. I turned to grab the jars full of healing salve and quickly turned back to the beast when a whimper escaped its jaws. I froze when I saw the brightest blue eyes looking up at me from its large furry head, which was still lying on the floor.

Another whimper escaped the wolf's mouth and my heart softened when pain penetrated his eyes. I didn't want to make any sudden moves and scare the creature, making it defensive and costing me my life, so I softly hummed while I unscrewed the lid to the ointment.

"I'm going to help you, okay." I told the wolf as I slowly reached towards him. I stopped just before I touched his skin, waiting to see how he would respond. He looked at me one more time, then closed his eyes and settled back down on the floor, not even flinching as I cared for him. Next, I took the clean strips of cloth next to me and wrapped up his wounds carefully while I continued to talk to him, telling him everything I was doing. When I was finished, I sat back and looked at the massive animal before me, who was now sleeping peacefully.

I reached out and softly scratched behind its ears. Its fur was so soft and the most beautiful color I have ever seen. It had a reddish-brown tint mixed with cream on its muzzle and underbelly. Now that I was done helping the poor creature, I could admire it for its beauty. I continued petting the wild animal for a few more minutes while telling him it was going to be okay.

Then I leaned forward and whispered next to his head, "thank you for rescuing me," before I quietly got up and found Tefyus asleep on one of

the bedposts. Looking back at the sleeping wolf, I was grateful I listened to the bird as I started to clean up the soiled cloths and put away the ointments.

Once I was finished, I sat on the bed and looked around, deciding what to do. I didn't want to leave the animal by itself in case it woke up in the middle of the night and caused havoc to our little home, but I also wanted the protection of my room.

I decided to stay in the infirmary.

I looked to Tefyus who was now awake and looking at me.

"Wake me if he wakes up, okay?"

Kaw. He quietly chirped.

I grabbed a blanket to lay on the bed next to my winged guardian and watch over the fur one who saved my life today. Once my head touched the pillow, a sense of security overcame me as my eyes fell, heavy with sleep. I knew I would be safe with these two animals around me, and sleep came easily.

I was walking in a meadow with the sun beating down on me while I was picking wildflowers for our table. I heard a howl and turned to see a black wolf coming out of the woods. I dropped the flowers and started to run in the opposite direction away from my nightmare.

"Emma, Wait!" I turned to the sound of a voice I've heard a million times in my dreams only to see a red wolf making its way towards me. I knew I was safe somehow. I stopped and reached my hand out towards the beast and the closer it got, I noticed it started to shift and become hazy. What was wrong with it?

"I'll help you!" I called out to the animal and started running across the meadow, but the nearer I got the larger it grew until the most handsome man I ever met with Auburn hair and piercing blue eyes was standing in its place.

"Emma."

"No. Where is my friend?" I started to look around for the wolf that needed my help, desperation settling on my chest as tears flowed down my cheeks.

"Emma, it's me."

“No. No.” I shook my head. “It can’t be you. You don’t want me.”

“Emma. Emma.”

Kaw! Kaw!

My eyes flew open at the sound, and I saw Tefyus flapping on my chest, and quickly turned to see the wolf laying on its stomach watching me with heavy eyes.

Taking a deep breath, I laid back down on the pillow, grateful my dream wasn’t real.

Tefyus swooped to the floor and hopped over to the wolf and nuzzled its jaw. The wolf let out a huff and closed its eyes once more.

After a few minutes, I got up to make breakfast and watched the wolf through the doorway to make sure it didn’t make any sudden moves. I would change the bandages tonight and see how the wounds were healing. The morning went by slowly as I tidied up the house and made some more salve. I wished grandmother was here with me, but I knew she couldn’t leave Madam White when she was about to deliver. I decided to write her a note to tell her the events of the night and the special guest that was now in her home. I would rather she know than come home early to find a wild animal in her house.

I wrapped the note to Tefyus’s leg with some string and gave him instructions.

“Give this to grandmother and wait for her reply.”

Watching the bird fly away brought about the reality that I was now alone with the wolf. I grabbed a book and brought a chair next to him so I could read while he slept, and also so I could have a constant eye on my wild guest. I was so caught up in the story that I didn’t notice he moved until he settled his large head on my feet with his back to me.

I froze, waiting to see if he would move again. He was warm and soft, and felt like a blanket covering my feet, but I had to remind myself he wasn’t a dog and could change his tune at anytime, but after a few minutes, his chest rose with even breaths, and I settled back down to read, only to be stopped when a wet sensation was on the top of my foot and found him licking me.

I pulled my feet back and tucked them under my chair, shocked at the sign of affection he was showing me. He tilted his head and looked up

at me with eyes that seemed to question my actions. Then He slowly stood up, and I panicked as his body towered over me. My head reached his chest as I looked up at his monster and how truly large he was.

How did I get him inside last night? My adrenaline must have given me strength.

He stepped forward until his muzzle was right in front of my face and we gazed into each other's eyes that were the same ones from my dream.

I didn't move. I could hardly breathe for fear this would take a turn for the worst.

I prayed Tefyus would return soon.

He tilted his head to the side and leaned forward, nuzzling my cheek with his nose, his sharp teeth so close to my skin.

I should jump up, run for it while I had the chance, but something inside me told me that I shouldn't fear this beast.

Which was ridiculous.

His wet nose brushed over my cheek, back and forth in an affectionate manner.

Then he licked my cheek.

I gasped at his show of affection, but he didn't stop there.

He licked my nose, then burrowed his face next to mine again, which made the chair lean back, and I let out a small cry for fear I would fall. The wolf stepped back, at my noise, making the chair rock forward.

Once settled, I gave the wolf a small smile, letting him know I was all right. He laid back down and closed his eyes.

I didn't move from my spot until the sun started to go down and realized I should probably make some supper. I quietly made my way into the kitchen, lighting candles along the way, trying not to disturb my furry friend. I realized now, that if he wanted to eat me, he would have done so already.

I heard a noise coming from the room he was laying in and found him sitting in the doorway, filling the whole frame, watching me with an intensity that almost made me self-conscious.

I cleared my thoughts and continued my task of making biscuits with a side of vegetables from our garden and some herbal tea.

He didn't move from the doorway, just observed my every move.

“Are you hungry?” I asked him, knowing he’d probably refuse since it wasn’t meat, but he limped forward.

“Wait, I’ll bring it to you,” I told him and brought over his meager meal, putting the plate on the ground before him, which he *wolfed* it down in no time.

Except for the vegetables.

“You don’t like them?” I said, pointing to the uneaten food, and he gave me a look that made me laugh.

“I figured,” then I grabbed more biscuits and placed them before him. I didn’t even have to get a broom, since he licked the crumbs clean off the floor.

I giggled at the absurdity of the situation. A large wolf was eating biscuits off my floor, like some pet.

While he was occupied, I made my way back into the apothecary to grab more salve and clean linen to change his bandages and check his wounds.

A felt a nudge in the middle of my back right as the room darkened, and I turned with my basket to see that he followed me into the apothecary and was blocking the whole doorway and any light from the other room.

I walked forward, hoping he would back away and let me pass, but instead he just sat on his haunches and turned his head to the side, showing me his neck. I figured it didn’t matter where I changed the bandages as long as it was done. When I brought the lantern closer he seemed to realize I needed more light and made his way back into the medical room with me in tow.

I carefully unwrapped the material, not wanting to reopen any wounds. He didn’t move as I worked to help him. Once all the bandages were gone from his neck, I leaned closer.

“I’m going to inspect your wounds.” I told him and he turned to me and nodded as if he understood. I wasn’t too alarmed since by now I figured this was no ordinary wolf with how intelligent he was.

I started to wonder if this was part of my gift as a healer. Thinking about animals, I realized Tefyus never came back with a note from grandmother and hoped he was okay.

Slowly moving the reddish brown fur around, so I could get a better view of the cuts, I couldn’t find even a scar that told me he was

injured at all. Then I unwrapped his front legs and saw the same thing; only newly grown fur.

“What are you?” I whispered to the beast. I’ve never seen wounds heal so fast. I knew he was not a normal wolf given his size, but no one could heal from such injuries with that speed, even with the best salves.

Instead of answering he just turned and placed his muzzle under my chin and lifted my head to meet his gaze that looked wild and familiar all at once. Then he licked my cheek one more time before heading towards the kitchen door. I placed my hand over my cheek and wondered why he was being so affectionate again and thought maybe it was just his way of thanking me.

Following the wolf, I realized he wanted out, and I was almost sad to let him go, but I knew I couldn’t keep him here.

I unlatched the lock, and he pushed through and made his way out the door and towards the dark forest. Before he entered, he turned towards me one last time, then lifted his head and howled to the moon. His song filled my heart, and I was sad when it ended. Then he leaped into the trees and was gone.

Chapter 14

Kaw!

I turned and found my feathered friend tapping on the window and noticed a new note was wrapped around his ankle. I set the broom down and unlatched one of the panes to let him in. He flew to the table and held out his foot for me to take the note. I unwrapped it and eagerly read what my grandmother had to say.

Emma,

First, I am glad you are safe. Madam White delivered a baby girl yesterday only a few hours after I received your note, which is why I didn't respond right away, but knew you would be safe. Tefyus has never led me astray, and I knew he would do the same for you.

It seems there is mischief afoot, and we need to be careful. Stay out of the woods and wear that rose ring with you when you go to town. It has a protection spell that will keep you safe, but we will talk more about that later. I should be back in the next few days since Madam White's labor was long and hard so I've placed another note with some salves I'd like you to make and deliver.

I know I can count on you.

Love, Grandmother

I looked at the other note she sent with a list of herbs and salves she wanted me to make and went straight to the apothecary. Pulling down jars from the shelves I had the ingredients mixed and ready to go in no time. I was proud of myself for what I have become and the trust grandmother put in me.

After cleaning up and checking the locks twice, I went upstairs to get ready for bed. Going straight to my jewelry box, I pulled out the rose ring and placed it on my finger. A calming sensation went over my body then quickly went away just as fast as it came.

Hmmm. Protection. I thought to myself and wondered what other things were out there that I needed to be aware of and what mischief

grandmother was talking about. It's been said that Tallour was a strange town but I was beginning to believe it as I thought about the last few days, attending to a gigantic wolf and the note I left downstairs. After a while, I finally fell asleep, too tired to dream.

Waking up when the sun just peeked over the trees, I got ready to deliver the salve to grandmother.

After getting dressed, I opened my window to let in some fresh air and found the autumn breeze was finally here. I grabbed my red cloak from the hook on the back of my door, headed downstairs to grab the basket, and make my way towards town.

I saw Tefyus asleep in the rafters and called to him to join me on my trip as I put on my cloak. He swooped down and landed on my shoulder where I scratched under his chin as I headed out the door.

I tucked the cloak tight around me as the chill of the morning air seeped into my bones. It was so different from the warmth of yesterday, but that could have been due to the adrenaline rush of running from and then saving a wolf.

Those thoughts made me alert as I made my way down the dirt road, and I looked at the ring once more, hoping it really had a protection spell on it. I don't know if I could handle any more scares like that so soon.

The town was still quiet since people were just rising for the day and gathering their items to sell at the market. I could smell the fresh bread baking when I walked past the bakery and my stomach grumbled, reminding me of the breakfast I had forgotten to eat. Maybe I could grab a pastry on the way back along with a few more baked goods for our meals. Satisfied with my plan I continued to make my way down the pebbled pathway that ran through the town towards the large manor in the distance.

Once I made my way to the door, I knocked and waited for someone to let me in. A man in a stiff uniform opened the door while looking me up and down.

I became nervous under his gaze, wondering if I had knocked on the wrong house.

"Yes?"

"My name is Emma. I am Healer Tully's granddaughter."

"Come in. She is expecting you." He told me, and relief went through me at his words. I entered and followed the man through the beautiful house that reminded me of my home back in Gale with its

grandeur. A sense of homesickness flooded me since I've only received a couple letters from my mother since my departure and I still haven't written her back since the last letter I received a couple weeks ago. I would do that today and tell her I was doing well and only write about my growth as a healer and leave out anything that had to do with wolves. She would send for me at once if she found out I was in any type of danger being here, but I have come to love the quiet, simple life, doing what I've always wanted even if I did have a scare the last couple of days.

"Through here, she is waiting for you." The butler opened the door and motioned me forward.

"Thank you, sir." I nodded towards him and entered the large room where I saw a woman sitting up in a large bed rocking a crying baby wrapped up in a blanket. Grandmother was off to the side pouring a cup of tea.

"Oh, Emma dear, come in!" Grandmother set the pot down and rushed towards me giving me a hug, then she lifted my hand and patted the rose ring that she gave me with a smile.

"Is this your granddaughter, Granny?"

"It is."

We both turned to the new mother, who looked exhausted, which was expected after labor, but her joy shined through as she looked from me and back to the whimpering infant.

"Granny Tully has done so much for me, and I can only imagine all that you are learning from her."

"I am learning so much and can only hope to be a great healer like her someday."

"Oh, but she tells me you are already a healer."

I looked at grandmother with raised brows, and she only smiled.

"I won't be around forever Emma, and you've learned enough to help those when I'm not around."

My cheeks flushed at her compliment.

"Thank you."

"Now, come take off your cloak, wash your hands, and I'll let you help me with the baby."

I quickly handed her my basket with the things she requested and took off my cloak. For the rest of the morning, I was instructed on the proper care of a newborn and its mother.

Holding the infant in my arms made me long for a family someday.

The feeling was new, since for so long I was against the idea, but the beautiful infant stirred something in my heart.

I wondered if my sister, Beth, would start forming one of her own since I had no prospects to even think about having a family.

Then a tall blacksmith came to mind, but I quickly brushed that away and my heart sank at the new longing that might never be fulfilled.

Around ten, Madam White called for brunch, and I was grateful for the meal she provided since the visit lasted longer than I expected.

We left around noon and headed back to our cottage, making our way through town.

“Thank you for letting me help. Adeline was so precious and small.”

“She was beautiful, wasn’t she? Life is so precious at that age, and we must do all we can to make sure they are taken care of.”

“I agree, it’s part of the reason I want to be a healer and I can only hope that one day...” I paused my thoughts when a laugh reached my ears.

I turned to see Rachel across the street leaning towards Ben and batting her eyelashes up at him.

He was leaning on the doorway that led into his forge with his arms crossed, which showed every muscle he earned with his trade as he listened intently to her. My heart pounded, and my stomach clenched as I watched their interaction.

“Don’t mind her, deary. He’s not interested.”

I whipped back around, embarrassed at being caught staring at the blacksmith.

Embarrassed at my thoughts from earlier.

“I don’t know what you are talking about?” I told her with a shrug then stomped forward, but soon stopped after a few steps, realizing I was acting rude and turned back to apologize, only to see her making her way towards the forge waving her hand in the air trying to get Rachel and Ben’s attention.

What was she doing!

“Yoo-Hoo, Benjamin.” The old woman hollered to him, and I could only stare in shock as he turned to her and smiled.

“Granny Tully, how are you? Then he looked around, “ and where is your...”

He stopped as he spotted me in the distance, his grin growing even broader.

I held back an eye roll. He didn't fool me for one second. And those words he declared weeks ago about how he wanted to be with me were false.

“Come, Emma, or do I have to tell the blacksmith the good news myself?” She waved me over.

I had no idea what she was talking about unless she wanted to tell him about the newborn I just held in my arms, not knowing if he would be interested in such news. I pulled myself together since everyone was now watching me and waiting for me to make my way over. I put on my best smile and manners for the people before me.

When I made it to grandmother's side, I gave a short hello to Ben and Rachel, not making eye contact with the handsome blacksmith, whose gaze I felt burning a hole through me.

“Oh, how I just love this color on you, it's beautiful.” Rachel touched my cloak and placed her other hand on Ben's forearm. “Don't you agree, Benny?”

Benny?

My resolve fell, and I practically glared at the man demanding an explanation.

He cleared his throat and moved his arm behind his back, making her drop her hand which didn't seem to phase her, and I waited for his answer.

He looked me straight in the eye and softly spoke, “It's not just the cloak, it's the person who's wearing it.”

Even though I wanted to call his bluff, my body betrayed me and I couldn't help the heat that entered my cheeks at his words. I turned to Rachel to see her reaction.

“Oh, you say that to everyone!” She giggled and touched his shoulder, and I wondered if what she said was true. I turned back and raised my eyebrows at him and saw that he moved slightly to the right away from her, and gave me a look that said it wasn't.

Then he turned to her and said, “Tell your father I'll have the list he sent me ready in the next two weeks, Miss Wendell. With the Harvest

Festival tomorrow and me being gone the last few days, I haven't caught up on my previous orders."

I wondered what kept him busy but realized I was also occupied.

A hurt wolf and all.

"How many times must I ask you to call me, Rachel." She playfully hit him on the arm. "You still haven't asked me to the festival, and it's tomorrow you know." She playfully scolded him and hope filled my chest that not only was she not on a first name basis, but I really wasn't a last resort when he asked me.

He looked at me with desperate eyes, that seemed familiar, but I couldn't quite remember the resemblance. He pursed his lips, not responding to her question.

Guilt swept through me when I recalled how I accused him of using me as a last resort, when in reality he did want to go with me. It was too late now since I knew he was a gentleman and would not refuse her request.

"Actually, that's why we've come!" Grandmother interrupted, and everyone turned to her. "Benjamin asked Emma a few days ago, but she's been so busy helping me that this is the first time she's had a chance to give her response." She turned and gave me a subtle wink.

I couldn't believe the words that were coming out of her mouth!

How did she know he asked me? Did she also know I had rejected him?

Embarrassment filled my whole body, and I knew I matched the color of the cloak I wore when I had to explain myself.

"And what's her answer?" My head whipped around to see Ben step in front of me and all his masculine glory. He grabbed my hand and stared into my eyes.

The words stuck in my throat and my body froze as if under a spell, forgetting where we were. I almost found my voice until he took a step closer and leaned down and breathed, "I hope it's a yes."

The only thing I could do was nod my head in response to his question and his smile grew.

"Oh, good!" Grandmother exclaimed, her response shaking me from the spell I was under, and I turned to look at her when I remembered the reason for her interference. Rachel had wide eyes and a mouth slightly open as she looked back and forth between me and Ben,

She was hurt and I instantly felt bad for what I did since she obviously wanted him to ask her, but I was so caught up in the moment that I didn't think about it. I had to make it right somehow.

"But I won't hog him all to myself; surely you can save a dance for Rachel?" I gave the blacksmith a look and was grateful when Ben obliged.

"It would be my pleasure." I gave a small smile to Ben as a thank you, which he returned with a nod of his head.

"Well, that settles it!" the girl clapped her hands with a smile on her face as her eyes lit up. "Maybe I'll ask Anthony, and we can all join in on the circle tomorrow?"

"Circle?" I asked.

"Oh, it's the best part of the festival!" She stepped forward and grabbed my hands as if she wasn't just rejected in front of us.

"We have a huge bonfire at night, and we all link arms and dance in a circle around the flames. Some call it the sweetheart circle, but that's just some oldwives tale."

Then she turned to face the busy town, "well, I better get going since Anthony doesn't know he's taking me to the festival yet." Then she made her way down to the street and entered the butcher's shop.

"Maybe things will be different this year?" Grandmother said and I looked to see her staring after the girl then back to me.

"Well, come home when you are done, deary."

"Done?" I questioned her.

Was she leaving me with Ben? I looked at him, my heart pounding in my chest.

I couldn't believe I was actually going to the festival with him.

"Well, you can't go to the festival without a new dress, now can you? I had one ordered for you a week ago and thought it would be perfect for the occasion."

"Oh, grandmother!" I set down my basket and gave her a hug. "You treat me far above what I deserve."

"Nonsense!"

"Won't you come with me?" I didn't want to go by myself and I wasn't about to ask the blacksmith to come with me.

"I'm tired, and these bones need a rest. You'll be fine, just come straight home after."

I nodded to her.

“I’ll go.”

I turned to Ben and was about to tell him I was fine walking by myself, but before a word left my mouth, grandmother exclaimed, “What a wonderful idea! What a gentleman you are.”

“It’s okay, I know you are busy.”

“I insist.” Then he held out his arm for me to take, and I placed my fingers right in the crook of it.

Warmth filled me to my toes as I smiled up at him, surprised to find such tenderness in his eyes as he looked back at me. Then he placed his other hand over mine as if to make sure I didn’t let go as we walked to the seamstress to pick up my dress.

An hour later, after a few alterations, we were finally out of the shop with my new dress folded in a box. We walked down the path in companionable silence until we almost made it to the cottage, and I turned to grab the box from him.

“I’m sorry it took so long. I know you are busy, but I appreciated your company.”

I thought about the list he was just given by Rachel’s father, and who knows what other request he was working on.

He didn’t hand me the box but instead moved it to hold it at his side as he stepped closer to me. “I’ll always have time for you, Emma. You’ve done so much for me already.”

I couldn’t think of anything I did for this man besides avoiding him the last month, and I scoffed at his flattery.

“If that were only true.”

“It is. Why don’t you ever believe me?”

I didn’t respond since I didn’t want to remind him of how I acted when he first asked me to the festival for fear he would take back his offer. Maybe he was referring to the salve I gave him, and I looked at his hands, wondering if it was helping.

“Are your hands doing better?”

His eyebrows pinched at my question.

“Is the salve helping your hands?”

Then he held them out to me.

“What do you think?” He held out the hand that wasn’t holding the box and I took it in my own to examine it. I ignored the warmth and

tingling that filled me as I looked over his strong fingers. There were no cracks to be seen. Only stains from his type of work.

“They seem to be healed.” I told him, then went to drop his hand, but he quickly twisted his fingers, interlocking mine with his, before pulling me to his side.

“Oh,” I smiled at his quick move that seemed to melt my heart.

“Shall we?” He grinned down at me, his eyes flicking to my lips for a split second.

I couldn’t speak, so I just nodded.

After we continued down the path, he lifted our hands.

“The reason they are healed is because you’re an amazing healer, Emma.”

“Thank you.” I softly responded. “I’ve been trying my best to learn from my grandmother.”

“She has a beautiful student.”

Did he mean it?

The cottage came into view and I saw grandmother in the kitchen. I stopped, not wanting to be caught holding this man’s hand since I didn’t know how she would react.

“I’ll take it from here. Thank you again.” I reached to take the box from him, but he stepped back, placing it out of my reach.

“When the full moon and the first day of autumn align, true love you are sure to find.”

“What?” I asked, confused, putting my hands out, so he could give me the box.

“It’s the old wives tale Rachel was talking about. Tomorrow is the full moon and while she may not believe in it...” He placed the box on the ground, stepped forward and cupped my cheek in his hand. His gaze drifted down to my lips, then back up, and I saw a slight hesitation in his eyes, which quickly turned to determination. “I do.”

Then he leaned forward and pressed his lips softly to mine, my whole body warming all the way down to my toes.

This had to be a dream.

He pressed closer, deepening the kiss before pulling back.

I soon realized I didn’t want it to end and wanted his lips back on mine, needing the connection I longed to have with this man before me.

Instead, I searched his eyes for answers and saw longing burning in his eyes as his thumb stroked over my mouth, leaving a tingly sensation behind.

Then he dropped his hand, closed his eyes, and bowed his head as if defeated. I cupped his face and pulled it down to meet my gaze. He looked so torn that my heart broke for him.

“What’s wrong, Ben?” I whispered, hoping he didn’t regret the kiss we just shared.

“Emma, I..I’m too dangerous for you. This could never work.”

I stepped back at his words, doubting filling me again that I would never be good enough for him.

This was the second time he’d said this, but I didn’t understand.

I started to turn, my broken heart couldn’t take it anymore.

“Then stop leading me on.” He had to know this game he was playing was wrong, even though my heart yearned for it to be true.

He quickly grabbed both my hands and pulled me towards his chest.

“I want it to work. I’ve never wanted something so bad in my life. I can’t just be your friend when I want so much more.” His eyes burned with truth and it filled my soul, but what was holding him back?

Why did he think he was too dangerous for me? The questions left my mind when he put one hand in my hair and brushed it back until he cupped the back of my neck. He gently pulled me towards him again and pressed another soft kiss to my lips. This time, I didn’t care about the consequences as I returned the gesture, wrapping my arms around his neck to deepen our kiss, telling him I didn’t just want to be friends either. His hands wrapped around my waist to pull me close. Hope soared through me that maybe it would work out after all.

After a few moments he released me only to kiss my forehead as he breathed in deeply.

“I’ll pick you up tomorrow evening.”

Then he turned to pick up the box and handed it to me. Once I secured it to my side he lifted his hand once more to cup my cheek.

“I meant what I said. All of it.”

I knew I was a fool, but I believed him with every fiber of my being.

I smiled at him, “You don’t have to be afraid, I’m not going anywhere.”

“I know.” Then he leaned forward one more time to press his lips gently to mine, then he turned and headed back down the road towards town.

I knew that no matter what he said or how dangerous he thought he was, it wouldn’t change how I felt about him now.

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Chapter 15

“I did it!” I exclaimed as the plants around my fingers grew several inches.

“See, I knew you could.” Grandmother said off to the side, giving me a broad smile. “I wonder what changed?” Then she winked.

I tucked my head as heat entered my cheeks. Last night when I came in after Ben walked me home, Grandmother was smiling from ear to ear as she looked towards the window, where I could plainly see the blacksmith walking back to town. Grateful she didn’t say anything as I helped her with dinner even though she kept giving me looks with wide eyes and a knowing smile.

Right before I rushed to my room to avoid any more of her playful taunting, she turned to me and said, “He’s a good man, Emma.”

“I know.” I softly told her, then headed towards the stairs.

“Wait, my dear.” I turned to see her coming towards me with a look of concern that replaced her smile and I got worried.

“Is everything alright, grandmother?”

“Yes, I just want you to be careful, okay. Not everything is as it seems.” Then she cupped my cheeks, and her smile returned.

“He’ll take care of you.”

“I know he will.”

Then I headed up to my room for the night. I thought about Ben’s warning and her words late into the night, wondering if she knew more than she let on.

After a restless night, I found grandmother in the kitchen, a question on my mind.

“Can emotions affect my magic?”

“Oh, yes. Emotions affect everything around us which is why it's important for a healer to be kind, understanding, and only show compassion towards those that need our help. Helping others is not based on what they can give us in return, but that it's the right thing to do. As you grow in these virtues, your powers will follow suit. Which means any of those opposite emotions can inhibit you.”

I loved it when she would give me words of wisdom as we practiced our skills daily. Not only was I growing in the art of healing, but my character was changing for the better as well, and it was all because of her. I thought about the time my powers did show, and the most recent one was my sister's wedding. I wanted her day to be perfect and I think the emotion of love towards her showed when my little garden was in full bloom just in time for her special event.

“You're right, grandmother.”

Then I thought on the emotions that were holding me back for so long. Envy, jealousy, and anger towards the blacksmith whenever I would see other young women around him, along with my own doubts in my skill. I was grateful one of those aspects was resolved, which made me think about the sweet kiss I shared with the man I've longed for since I came to this town.

I turned back towards the plants, not wanting grandmother to see the blush that entered my cheeks when I thought of his lips on mine. That's probably what was making the plants grow now, since my heart was full with thoughts of the blacksmith and what was growing between us. I didn't know if it was love, but I knew I cared for him deeply. A gasp left my mouth when the plants grew even bigger right before my eyes, and it only confirmed it.

A chuckle left grandmother's lips as she watched me with a knowing smile. and I joined in on the laughter, realizing I shouldn't hide how happy I was. This place, my new home, was turning out to be the best thing that ever happened to me and I was flourishing just like these plants were.

“That should be enough for now, deary. Let's get ready for the festival.”

We headed inside, and I went straight to the greenhouse where we kept the plants that did not do well in the colder climate that was now upon Tallour. I made my way straight to the lemon tree and blueberry bush noticing the fruit wasn't quite ripe yet, but as I reached out and touched the small lemons with my fingers to see if they would be efficient enough. Then the same familiar tingling sensation left my fingers and they grew in my hand.

The largest lemon now hung from its branches, and its scent filled the air.

I went forward to pluck the fruit from the tree when a loud cracking noise filled the air. I turned and saw the branch holding the lemon could not handle the weight and I quickly plucked the fruit off the branch to relieve it of the fruit I accidentally grew. I felt bad for hurting the plant when I didn't mean to. I reached out and wrapped my hand around the place where the branch broke and saw the leaves lift up to their original place. I removed my hand and saw the branch fully healed and stepped back in wonder looking at my hands. I grabbed the rest of the fruit and rushed back to the kitchen realizing my energy was lower than before as I entered and had to stop to catch my breath.

"Grandmother, can healers actually heal? Like, wounds and such?"

She looked up from the bowl she was mixing the ingredients and pinched her lips. "Yes, but it's something we try to avoid."

"Really, why?" I stepped forward and showed her the large lemon and explained what had happened.

"Think of how many people we could help?"

"It's too dangerous. It's different from helping herbs grow since it not only uses our magic, but our life force itself. There is only so much a healer can do without putting their own life in danger, and I can't let that happen to you..."

Then she got quiet and turned away from me, "...not like I let it happen to your mother."

She grabbed the bowl and walked to the other side of the kitchen, and I followed, eager to know what happened that stopped my mother from fulfilling her destiny.

“What happened, grandmother? Please tell me?” I pleaded with her. She took a deep breath and looked at me with deep pain that I knew was from years of guilt.

“I need to know.” I told her softly.

I could see her resolve to not tell me, dissolving.

“It was a dark and stormy night when one of the farmer’s brought their son in, who had been trampled by a herd of cows while trying to wrangle them in from the storm. They got spooked when the lightning struck, and he didn’t move in time. He was on the brink of death since he was internally bleeding and had many broken bones. I told him there was not much we could do, but your mother insisted. I told her no repeatedly, but she did not listen.”

Tears filled her eyes as she continued. “I went to grab some tea and salves to ease his pain for his last moment on this earth, and I came back to see your mother passed out on the floor and the boy healed from the accident. It was only due to my years of training that I was able to bring her back, but it took weeks for both of us to recover.”

“But everyone lived.”

“Yes, but at what cost?” Then she gave me a stern look. “I forbid you just as I forbid her.”

“Yes.” I quietly responded, knowing I could not change her mind and it was probably for the best.

She put a hand on my arm.

“I don’t want to lose you like I lost your mother. After the incident she hid her power, and in her fear, she ran away. It was only after a year that I finally received a letter about her whereabouts. I begged her to come home, but she refused.”

I reached out to comfort her. “She loves you, grandmother, never doubt that. She trusts you enough with her own daughter, and I know one day you’ll see her again.” I would write to Mother tonight and ask her to visit and pray she would.

“Now, enough gloom for one day.” She told me with a pinched smile, trying to lighten the mood, but I could still see the pain of the past haunting her. “We have a festival to get you ready for and a blacksmith to charm!”

“Oh, Grandmother!” I laughed and hugged her once more, accommodating her change of conduct. Then I headed upstairs, pondering on the story of my mother and how great power can also cause great suffering if not used within its proper bounds. Hoping that I would never have to make that choice one day.

Once I entered my room I tried to put those thoughts away for now. After all, I did have a blacksmith to charm.

Chapter 16

I finished tying up the laces that secured the bodice of my gown and looked in the mirror to make sure everything was in place. The dress was beautiful, and I was surprised the navy blue material made my muddy brown eyes seem more intense than their normally dull hue.

I was so happy with the gift grandmother gave me, and I would make sure she knew how grateful I was for it. While I've been saving the coins she gave me for the work I helped her with, I didn't feel the need to buy new gowns since the ones I brought with me were still in good condition. Plus I didn't have a special occasion that required such a purchase...until now.

I completed the look by putting my hair half up and out of my face. Then I went to my jewelry box and took out the rose ring grandmother gave me and slipped it on my finger.

"Hurry up, deary!" Grandmother called to me from downstairs, and I grabbed my cloak, making my way down the stairs to see her waiting by the door with a basket full of treats she made for the festival.

"Oh, what a beauty you are, Emma."

"Yes, she is." I turned and saw Ben standing off to the side with a grin on his face. He wore black pants with a crimson color shirt that almost matched my cloak and a black jacket over it. He looked beyond handsome, and I couldn't believe he came, even though he said he would.

"You came!" I ran to him and threw myself into his arms. He caught me and spun me around the room, then set me on my feet and I blushed when I realized what I had just done. It only deepened when he did not let go but pulled me closer.

"Now, save that for the dancing, Benjamin. We've got a festival to attend!" Grandma chuckled, and I quickly stepped back from his embrace, remembering we had an audience.

Grandma headed out the door, and he held out his arm for me to take. We followed behind her, not minding the slow pace she set since it only gave us time to be together without interruption.

The festival was held just outside of town in a large field owned by Jed Brown, one of Tallour's local farmers. He raised all sorts of stock, and it was perfect for the event. In the distance, we could see people setting up tables and chairs while the children played games together away from the setup. In a spot where grass was sparse; Anthony was chopping wood while his younger brother, Isaiah, gathered the logs and handed them to their father, who was building a dome that would be the bonfire for tonight.

I looked around for Rachel, surprised she wasn't there ogling at the young man she intended to bring to the festival.

"Benjamin! Emma!" We turned to see Rachel holding onto a man's arm that was far from the Butcher's son. My eyes went wide as they came towards us wondering, how she came to be in his company.

Ben stepped in front of me with his hands out to the side and if I didn't know it before with his threat, I knew it now.

His brother was dangerous.

Ben's protective stance told me all I needed to know.

"Phil. I told you to stay away." Ben hissed at the man who was almost identical to him as they stepped up to greet us.

Rachel's eyes became wide as she noticed the hostility between the two.

The man smirked, "But I've been invited, Brother, by this beautiful young lady." He turned to the young girl and grabbed her hand to kiss it while looking at her eyes with false adoration that anyone could spot, but Rachel didn't seem to notice as she reddened, letting a giggle escape her lips.

"Leave now." Ben threatened, "You don't belong here, and I don't want anyone getting hurt. These people are good people."

I turned to Ben, wondering what he was talking about.

I stood up on my toes, putting a hand on his shoulder since I was still behind him so I could reach his ear and whispered, “Is everything okay? Should I get the constable?”

Then I looked around to see where the constable was and spotted him on the far side of the field helping the men set up for the night.

“No.” He quickly spoke and turned to me with worry in his eyes. Was this why he told me to stay away from him, that he was dangerous, because of his brother?

Then he turned back to his brother, “because he’s going to leave now.”

He only sneered, “But why should you get all the *fun*? Surely you can share.” Then he stepped towards me and a growl left Ben’s chest in the most feral noise I’ve ever heard. It was as if a wolf was buried deep within him.

The man laughed and stepped back to take Rachel’s arm, “Come on sweetheart. I think you owe me a dance.”

“Yes.” She said hesitantly, looking between the two men as she grabbed Phil’s arm and led him to where the festivities were about to begin.

“What’s going on?” I moved to Ben’s side as he watched the couple leave, his brows pinched with worry. When he didn’t respond I gently cupped his face and brought his gaze down to mine. He blinked a few times as if he just noticed I was there and gave me a small smile. Reaching up to place his hands over mine as he let out a sigh.

“Don’t let him ruin our night. While I don’t know what’s going on, I trust you, Ben.”

“I wish you wouldn’t.”

“Well, good thing it’s my decision then.” I smiled, trying to lighten the mood while grabbing his arm to continue walking towards the festival.

He stopped and turned me towards him and gently placed his hands on my shoulders.

“If anything happens tonight and I tell you to run, you run. Understand? No matter what, you get yourself out of here.”

“Nothing is going to happen.” I tried to assure him, hoping what I said was true.

“Please.” He begged.

I took a deep breath, hoping his worries were unfounded since I was looking forward to spending the evening with him.

“I will.”

Then he pulled me towards him and kissed me gently on the forehead, and I blushed from his open affection towards me and hoped no one was looking our way, but instead of pulling back, I decided to be bold and kiss him on the lips in return.

He chuckled, “maybe it’s you that someone needs to keep an eye on tonight. You’re already causing trouble.”

“Only the best kind of trouble,” I grinned.

Then I grabbed his hand and pulled him towards the others, anticipating the fun night ahead of us.

Chapter 17

“Gather around the bonfire! It’s time for the sweetheart’s dance!”

Overseer Wendell called out to everyone.

I turned to Ben, recalling yesterday when he told me how he believed the tale to be true, and found him staring at me with the most loving gaze while holding his hand out to me. I set the lemon tart I had in my hand down on the table and placed my hand in his. My heart quickened as he led me to the blazing fire before us, where other couples were gathering to start the dance that was destined for lovers.

Once he brought me to the circle where we stood side by side, he brought my hand to his lips and gently kissed my fingers while gazing into my eyes. My cheeks burned as he leaned forward and whispered in my ear.

*“When the full moon and the first day of autumn align, **true love** you are sure to find.”*

My breath caught at his meaning, but I didn’t have time to respond as the music started and the steps to the dance began. Everyone linked arms around the flames and stepped to the right as one. Then we tapped with our right foot, then our left, and stepped back to the left. Repeating a few times before we unlinked arms and turned towards the one we brought to the circle with us.

We grabbed each other’s hands before spinning around together. Laughter left my lips.

This is what joy felt like. To be with someone you loved.

As I looked at Ben, who’s eyes sparkled in the moonlight, I knew he felt the same way. My whole body filled with this emotion as we continued to dance together into the night.

I never wanted it to end.

It was magical, and not the kind that I was still learning as a healer. This was ancient magic, so deep and pure. It’s not one you are born with but can only grow with someone else. So strong and powerful no force on earth could ever break it in its truest form.

I felt so privileged to be able to feel and share that with the man before me.

The music slowed, and I turned to Ben, who grabbed my hand and led me away from the others. My heart still beating from our dance only increased the farther we got away from the crowd.

When we were just outside the light of the fire, he pulled towards him, cupping my face and gently running his thumbs along my cheeks.

“Emma, I love you so much.”

My heart burst at his admission, and I had to tell him how I felt.

“Ben, I...”

Then a scream penetrated the air.

We froze, turning to see what was wrong and saw Rachel scrambling out of the woods. Her dress was torn and she had blood on her sleeve. Tears streamed down her cheeks as she ran towards us.

“He’s a...He’s a...” she tried to speak as she pointed to the woods.

We ran to her, and she grabbed my arms, her whole body shaking with fear.

“What happened! Who did this to you?” We turned and saw her father and some of the men running towards us. Then a vicious snarl came from the place in the woods she had just ran from, and I looked to Ben for answers.

“Run!” He turned to me, desperate in his voice. “Run, Emma!”

I didn't move. Fear pulsing through me.

“Now!” He cried.

“I can’t.” I shook my head. “I have to help her.” I said moving towards Rachel, as the men pulled out their knives to face the creature that was hidden in the darkness of the forest.

“No, it doesn’t matter!”

“I’m a healer, Ben! I have to help.”

Then a familiar voice came from the woods, and a chill went down my spine.

“Come out, Ben! Show them what you really are!”

Then Phil stepped into the moonlight and I noticed blood on his mouth as he formed a truly evil smile. “You’re not one of them! They’ll never accept you!” He spat.

Suddenly, arms wrapped around me as I was pulled into a fierce hug as if it was the last one we would have. Then he pressed his lips to the top of my head and spoke, “No matter what happens. Know I love you. I’m sorry.” Then he let me go and walked towards his brother with determination in his step.

“Leave this town alone. Your quarrel is with me.”

“Oh, if only.” His brother laughed, sounding like a mad man, that pierced fear straight into my heart. “Once I’m finished with you, I’ll pick off each one of them, starting with your lovely lady friend.” Then he looked at me and grinned wickedly.

I wanted to hide and wished I would have heeded Ben’s warning when I had the chance.

“You won’t get the chance.” Ben snarled back and started to run towards his brother, who met him head-on.

At the last second, they leaped towards one another with fingers spread wide, ready to tear the other apart, only to clash in a large heap of fur as two wolves emerged from their bodies.

I couldn’t believe the transformation that happened right before my eyes as they fought with brutality. Realizing that Ben was the wolf that came to me that night when Tefyus urged me to open the door and his brother was the black wolf who attacked me on my way here and then haunted my dreams. Aiming for each other’s necks as they swiped at each other’s bodies trying to get the upper hand, I wondered what I could do.

That’s when I heard the uproar around me as the town scattered to escape the two werewolves that were not just a tale to scare little children at night.

Then I heard a loud whimper and turned to see the black beast throw Ben down with a large thump on the ground that vibrated straight through my body. The large mass of red fur didn’t move, and I prayed he wasn’t dead.

I stepped forward and the black beast turned towards me and snarled as he stepped over his brother and leaped towards me. I turned and ran hearing the snarls behind me, my heart bursting out of my chest. I fumbled with the clasp of my cloak as I ran trying to get rid of the extra weight that was slowing me down. I heard a growl right behind me and ducked hoping that if he leapt, he would miss me.

A sound vibrated through me and I turned to see a dome of thin red swirls surrounding me. I looked to my hand and saw the rose ring glowing and remembered grandmother's words.

The black wolf charged again, trying to break the barrier only to be pushed back and flung to the ground. After a few times I noticed the barrier was starting to weaken and I prayed for a miracle as I dug my hands into the earth hoping my idea would work. My hands started to tingle in my desperation for safety as I searched deep within myself, pouring my magic around me. Roots shot up from the ground and encircled the dome, creating a thick cage that saved me from the next attack. I continued to pulse my power into the ground, but I could tell my energy was draining fast.

"Emma! Emma! I'm coming!" came a voice in the distance.

No! Not grandmother!

"Stay back! Save yourself!" I hollered. I couldn't have her getting hurt, it would tear me apart to lose the person who has helped me grow in so many ways these last months, not when I already lost the one person I have come to love.

I could hear the roots being torn apart and knew my end was coming. I saw the yellow eyes through the branches and the snarl as sharp claws and fangs scraped and chewed their way through my barrier.

Then, a familiar howl filled the air, and hope filled my chest. The barrier rattled and I looked through the hole that was scraped away by sharp claws to see Ben's fangs around the offender's neck as he flung him away from me. He shook him until the beast went limp in his mouth. Then he dropped the still body and sat back on its haunches, lifting its head to the sky and howling to the moon in a mournful cry.

My heart reached out to him at what he had to do. Even the right choice can be a painful one, and I knew he was hurting. Then he stood up and started to walk towards me, but he started to sway and fell down in a large lump of fur. Desperation to get to him had me pushed against my barrier, kicking at the roots that once were my savior, were now my obstacle.

I heard a commotion and saw the townspeople had come back with pitchforks and torches. No doubt coming to finish off the beast. I kicked with all my might one more time and finally broke through. I saw grandmother standing in front of Ben, and I made my way towards them. Her hands were raised as she called up on her own barrier to protect us.

“Back away, healer!” the overseer called out. “They are demons that need to be dealt with!”

“No! Ben saved this town, and you are fools if you don’t recognize it!”

“One good deed does not change what he is!” He argued back. Shouts of agreement filled the air.

“He’s dangerous.”

“What about the children?”

“We’re not safe here!”

“Kill them!”

“How can you say that when you have your own secrets, Wendell.” The old healer cried.

The overseer stepped back, a look of worry on his face, and I wondered what he was hiding.

Or who?

“That is different, and you know it. She would never harm anyone,” He hissed quietly.

“Is it?” Grandmother shot back, then looked around at everyone, “many of you have secrets, but do we shun you? No, we welcome you into our little town.”

Shouts filled the air and I worried they would not see reason.

I hugged the red fur that was matted with blood, and I detected a small heartbeat.

“You’re alive,” I cried softly, tears filling my eyes. I, for sure, thought I had lost him.

Hope stirred within me. I turned to the townspeople before I did something I promised I wouldn’t do to try and convince them one more time.

“How can you condemn one man for something he didn’t do? He saved you, and you are blinded by fear! He’s lived peacefully among you, being your friend, sharing his talents, and being a great contributor to this town. If you kill him now you will be murderers, not him!”

The town went silent at my words and a little boy stepped forward. I recognized him as William, the carpenter’s son, we had healed not too long ago.

“Ben saved me. I didn’t know he was the wolf at the time, but when the black wolf attacked me, it was Ben who protected me.” Then he looked

up at his father, tugging on his sleeve. “Don’t hurt him, papa. He saved me.”

He brushed his son’s hair back, and put down the tool he brought to the attack the werewolf with and looked around at the others.

“Williams right, we owe this man our life. He not only saved my little boy, but this town.”

I looked around, and slowly everyone put their weapons down and nodded towards each other in agreement.

Grandma took down the barrier and turned to me.

“Hurry, we must get him back to the cottage while we have time.”

“No, grandmother. He won’t make it.” Then I gave her a fierce hug and whispered, knowing what I had to do.

“I love you Grandmother. Thank you.”

Then I turned to the wolf who became my friend and also the man I loved. Placing my hands on him, I searched deep within for the power that I needed to heal him.

“No! Emma!” Grandmother shouted, but it was as if she was in the distance. “Don’t do this!” she cried.

My hands started to tingle, and the sensation went all the way up my arms until it filled my chest. Power like never before surged from me, and it came from the love I felt for this man. It went down to the very core of who I was. I was nothing without him and this was my gift to him in return for saving this town, saving me. He healed my soul, and now it was my turn to return the favor.

Chapter 18

(Epilogue)

3 Months Later

My fingers dug into the ground, and my power filled the cold soil around me. Beautiful white roses grew at a rapid pace in a perfect line that formed the path in the snow-covered field by the cottage, where I would take my first steps to become the blacksmith's wife. After twenty feet or so they grew to the sky and rounded on the top, connecting in the middle to create a beautiful arch.

“Your gift is strong, daughter.” I turned to my mother who was here for the event and watching me create the perfect scenery for my wedding that was tonight under the full moon. Even though it was the middle of winter I knew my flowers would hold up. I thought back to the day when I almost lost the man I was about to marry. How I almost lost my life to give him his, but luckily grandmother got to me just in time and I was able to heal and return to my full strength within a few weeks.

I turned to her and smiled, so grateful she came when I wrote her the wonderful news, scared she would be hesitant to return to her home after so many years since she ran away. Grandmother was more than thrilled and I've never seen her spirits so high since her daughter returned.

“Thank you, Mother, for believing in me and letting me come.”

Kaw!

I turned and Tefyus flew to my shoulder and brushed his head up against mine in an affectionate manner. I scratched under his chin, and he flew away to land on the shoulders of the man who would soon be my husband. I waved to him as he headed our way.

“I knew you were destined for this Emma, and I couldn’t keep you from it.” She told me softly, “Or from him.” Then she turned to me and pulled me into a tight hug and everything felt right in the world as I watched her walk back to the cottage giving Ben and I a moment together before we became united as one.



Taking my first steps down the rose covered aisle, I looked up at the man who would soon be my husband. My stomach clenched with anticipation as his auburn hair waved in the breeze, reminding me of the wolf he really was and the man I came to love. Lanterns were placed along the aisle and I could see that the whole town had come for our wedding even though the winter chill nipped their cheeks, but you wouldn’t know with the smiles they were giving us.

With each step my red cloak flowed behind me and my white dress underneath shimmered in the moonlight. The red in my cheeks wasn’t due to the cold though, but the joy that filled me at the commitment I was about to make.

Then taking my last steps, I faced Ben and saw his eyes glowing with love and longing for me. He grabbed my hands in his, and we both turned to face the priest who would marry us.

After our vows were made, Ben turned me towards him and cupped my face, searching my eyes as I anticipated our kiss.

“Emma, I never thought I could have a life like this. Not with what I was. You have given me that and so much more, and I can’t wait to share it with you.”

Then he wrapped his hands around my waist and pulled me in to press his soft lips to mine in a tender and loving kiss. My hands reached up and wrapped around his neck, pulling him closer, not wanting it to end.

The crowd cheered, and I released him as we laughed, remembering our audience, our cheeks flushing under the moonlight for all to see.

Then he grabbed my hand and lifted it up with his and the crowd cheered louder. Once we made our way back down the aisle everyone made their way to the bonfire where we would celebrate union.

The night was full of dancing and laughter with family and friends. When the bonfire started to slowly die many made their way back to their homes. I turned to look at Ben as a yawn escaped my lips, and he had a mischievous smile on his face.

“What?” I blushed.

“Come with me, I know the perfect way to get you home. Our home.”

I wondered if he was going to pick me up and carry me to his shop, but instead, he led me towards the woods.

He dropped my hand and walked about ten feet in front of me and turned.

“I love you, Emma, and not just as a man, but all my forms.”

Then right before my eyes he transformed into the beautiful red wolf that I’ve grown to love and care for, even before I knew it was actually him. I ran to him and wrapped my arms around his large furry neck and snuggled up against his fur.

“I love you, Ben. All of you.” Then I turned and placed a kiss on his furry neck and he licked my cheek in return. I stepped back and he laid down motioning with his head towards his back. I hesitated at first, then made my way to his side and climbed on his back, sitting in the center. He slowly got up, and I quickly wrapped my arms around his neck so I wouldn’t fall, his soft fur creating a blanket of comfort as his warmth seeped into me. Then he made his way towards town, where we would start our new life as a healer and the red wolf of Tallour.

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